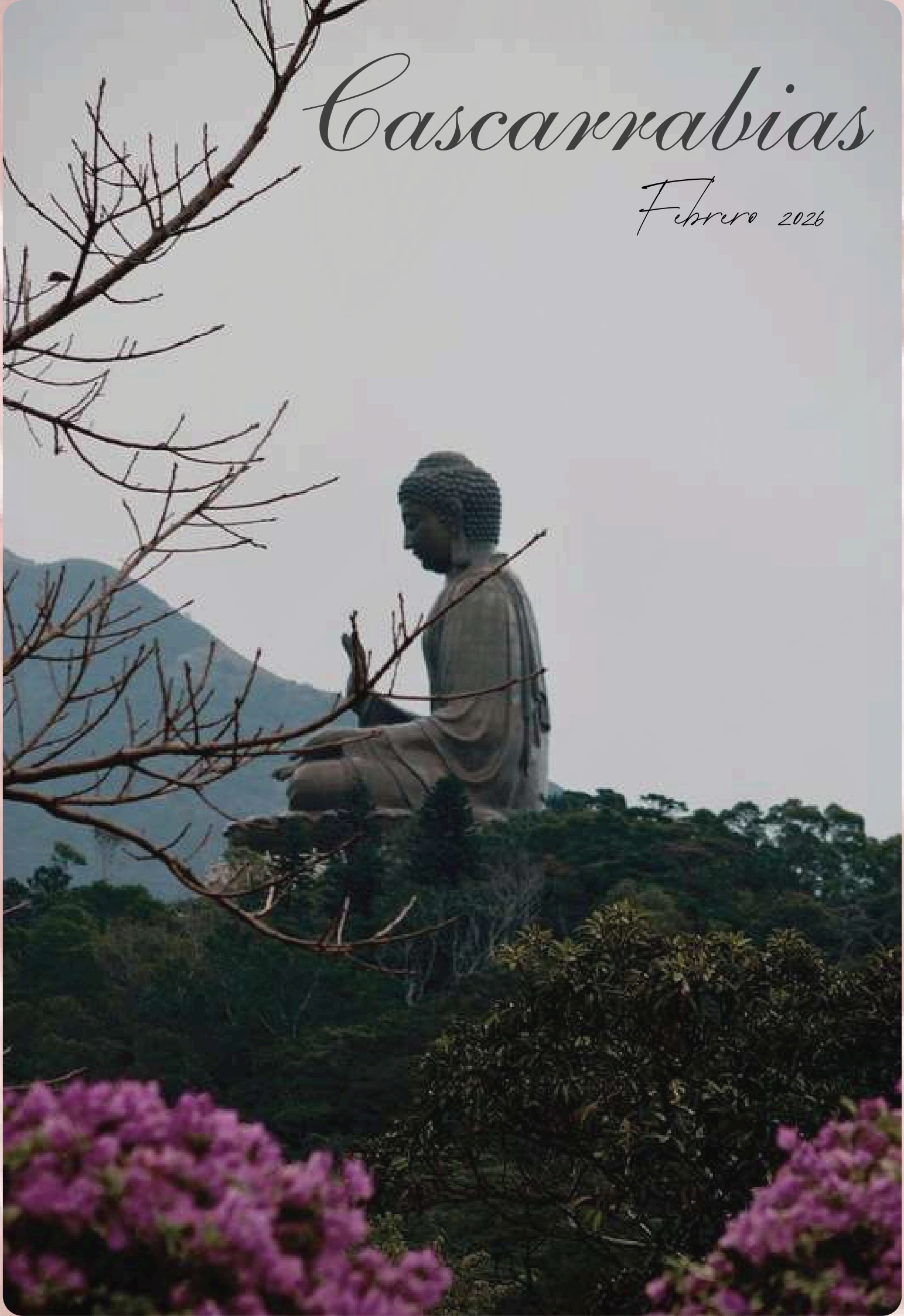


Cascarrabias

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Cascarapias

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Photography

Sobre La Portada

Esta foto muestra el famoso Gran Buda de Hong Kong, sentado en lo alto de una colina y rodeado de naturaleza. La estatua está en una posición de meditación, sentada con las piernas cruzadas y el cuerpo recto, lo que representa calma y paz interior.

Una de sus manos está levantada con la palma hacia afuera. Este gesto significa protección y tranquilidad. La otra mano descansa sobre su pierna, simbolizando generosidad y equilibrio.



La imagen transmite serenidad y respeto. El Buda, junto con las montañas y las flores en primer plano, crea una sensación de armonía entre la naturaleza y la espiritualidad. Al viajar a Asia tuve la oportunidad de tomar muchas otras fotos en las cuales

Esta imagen es parte de mi viaje a Asia, donde pude experimentar de cerca nuevas culturas, tradiciones y formas de vida. Aunque fue un viaje corto, me permitió observar y vivir momentos diferentes a los que estoy acostumbrado. Por lo cual aquí ahí otras photos que se me hicieron representan la belleza de lugares como Hong Kong, Vietnam y muchos otros:



Artículos



EL AMOR EN LOS TIEMPOS DE LA TECNOLOGÍA

Fernanda Olmos

En cada época, el amor ha adoptado distintas formas. Desde las cartas escritas a mano hasta los mensajes instantáneos, la manera de expresar los sentimientos ha cambiado, pero la esencia sigue siendo la misma: la necesidad humana de conexión, comprensión y afecto. En los tiempos actuales, el amor se vive de forma más rápida, más visible y, en muchos casos, más compleja.

Amor en la era digital

Vivimos en una era donde la tecnología forma parte de casi todos los aspectos de nuestra vida: estudiamos en línea, nos informamos a través de redes sociales y nos comunicamos con un solo clic. En este contexto, el amor también ha cambiado su forma de expresarse y construirse.

Las redes sociales y las aplicaciones de mensajería han transformado la manera en que nos conocemos y nos relacionamos. Plataformas como Instagram, TikTok y WhatsApp permiten que estemos conectados las 24 horas del día. Esto facilita el contacto, pero también puede generar malentendidos, dependencia emocional o comparaciones constantes con las relaciones que vemos en línea.

Hoy en día, muchas relaciones comienzan con un “like” o un mensaje directo. La tecnología acorta distancias, pero también puede hacer que las conversaciones sean más superficiales si no existe una comunicación sincera. La tecnología facilita conocer personas que viven lejos, mantener relaciones a distancia y compartir momentos importantes al instante. Sin embargo, también puede generar malentendidos, celos por lo que se ve en redes o presión por mostrar una relación “perfecta” en internet.

Aunque hablamos más que nunca por medio de pantallas, no siempre existe una conexión profunda. Los mensajes pueden ser rápidos y prácticos, pero a veces carecen del tono y la emoción que transmite una conversación cara a cara.

El reto actual es usar la tecnología como una herramienta para fortalecer los vínculos, no para reemplazar el diálogo sincero y el tiempo de calidad juntos.

Más libertad, más responsabilidad

En la actualidad, las personas tienen mayor libertad para elegir cómo y con quién compartir su vida. Se habla más abiertamente sobre distintos tipos de relaciones, respeto por la diversidad y la importancia del consentimiento. El amor ya no responde a un único modelo tradicional, sino que se construye a partir de acuerdos, valores y proyectos en común.

Sin embargo, esta libertad también implica mayor responsabilidad emocional. Aprender a comunicar lo que sentimos, establecer límites sanos y respetar el espacio del otro son habilidades fundamentales para que una relación funcione.

En el mundo digital, el respeto es fundamental. Cuidar la privacidad de la otra persona, no compartir información sin permiso y evitar el ciberacoso son aspectos esenciales del amor responsable.

Amor propio: la base de todo

Uno de los cambios más importantes en nuestra época es la importancia que se le da al amor propio. Cuidar la salud mental, reconocer nuestro valor y no depender completamente de otra persona para ser felices es un mensaje que cada vez tiene más fuerza entre los jóvenes.

El amor sano no significa ausencia de conflictos, sino la capacidad de resolverlos con diálogo y empatía.

Un sentimiento que no cambia

Aunque las formas cambien, el amor sigue siendo una experiencia universal. Nos inspira a través de canciones, películas, libros y sueños. En tiempos actuales, el desafío es encontrar un equilibrio entre la tecnología y la conexión real, entre la independencia y el compromiso.

En definitiva, el amor en los tiempos actuales no es mejor ni peor que antes: es diferente. Y como toda experiencia humana, requiere aprendizaje, respeto y autenticidad.

La confianza también juega un papel importante. Revisar constantemente el celular de la pareja o desconfiar por cada interacción en redes puede dañar la relación. La base sigue siendo la misma de siempre: comunicación, respeto y honestidad.

Aunque cambien las formas, los sentimientos siguen siendo auténticos. El amor en los tiempos de la tecnología no es menos verdadero; simplemente se expresa de manera diferente.

La clave está en encontrar un equilibrio: aprovechar las ventajas que ofrece la tecnología sin olvidar que las relaciones más fuertes se construyen con empatía, tiempo y presencia real.



SAVE



ARE MANGROVES THE KEY TO SAVING OUR PLANET?



By: Jaida Vedde

Although you might have heard of mangroves before, you probably thought they were just like any other tree, didn't you? What you probably didn't know is that mangroves are one of the most important ecosystems on the planet, and they could be the key to our survival.

Mangroves are trees that grow on coastlines in tropical and subtropical areas, or in simpler terms, they grow where freshwater and saltwater meet. If you have ever seen a mangrove tree before, you may have noticed how while much of their strong, thick, tangled roots are underwater, the other half is above water. This is because the roots need to be exposed to take in oxygen. Our human eye sees the ecosystem above water, but what's underwater tells a completely different story.

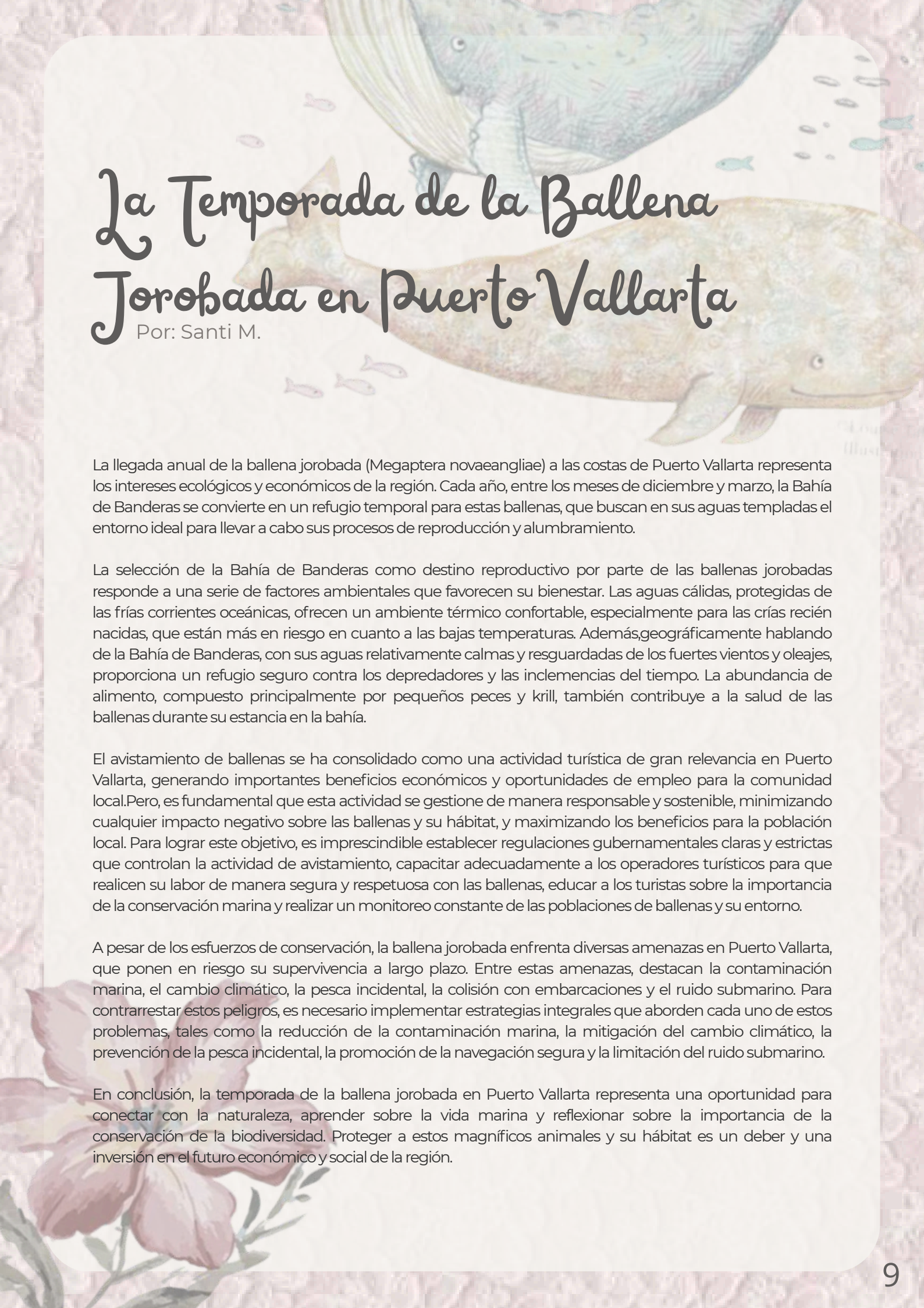
Mangrove forests serve numerous purposes, including providing habitat for over 2,000 animal species, improving water quality, fighting climate change, and defending communities against coastal erosion, storms, and flooding.

Have you ever used a filter in your fish tank to keep the water clean? Have you ever wondered how coastal waters stay clean? Well, the answer is mangroves. Mangroves' unique root structure slows down the flow of water, working like a net, allowing contaminants like heavy metals, excess nutrients, sediment, and debris to settle out. Then the bacteria in the mangrove soil eat or break down the chemicals. About 90% of nitrates, phosphates, and suspended solids get filtered out before going into the ocean. Filtering the water also keeps it clear so sunlight can penetrate to the bottom and help coral reefs and seagrass thrive. So mangroves act as a filter, keeping the coastal waters clean.

On the news, scientists explain how coastal areas are suffering from floods and erosion. Well, there's good news: if you have mangroves nearby, you don't have to worry as much about it. The mangroves' intertwined roots work as a wall or a barrier and slow down waves, storm speeds, and coastal flooding. It's known that mangroves reduce flood risk for about 15 million people per year.

Even if you don't live in a coastal area, these forests are important to you. Do you know what the biggest cause of global warming is on our planet? Yes, that's right, CO₂, carbon dioxide. When we burn oil, coal, or natural gas, we take carbon dioxide that was locked underground for millions of years and put it back into the atmosphere. This then causes more greenhouse gases, leading to global warming, but what if I told you that mangroves store four times more CO₂ than normal forests? All trees absorb carbon dioxide, but when normal trees fall, that CO₂ goes back into the atmosphere. When the mangroves fall, they fall into the water and sediment, where layer upon layer of CO₂ accumulates, locking the carbon remains underground for hundreds if not thousands of years, so mangroves also help prevent and reduce global warming, which affects us all.

But in the last 50 years, about one-third of the world's mangroves have been destroyed due to several human activities, such as climate change, shrimp farming, deforestation, and coastal development. But it's not too late: now that you know what you know, spread it. We need to educate people about the importance of these incredible trees and how they can save us. But for them to save us, we have to save them first.



La Temporada de la Ballena Jorobada en Puerto Vallarta

Por: Santi M.

La llegada anual de la ballena jorobada (*Megaptera novaeangliae*) a las costas de Puerto Vallarta representa los intereses ecológicos y económicos de la región. Cada año, entre los meses de diciembre y marzo, la Bahía de Banderas se convierte en un refugio temporal para estas ballenas, que buscan en sus aguas templadas el entorno ideal para llevar a cabo sus procesos de reproducción y alumbramiento.

La selección de la Bahía de Banderas como destino reproductivo por parte de las ballenas jorobadas responde a una serie de factores ambientales que favorecen su bienestar. Las aguas cálidas, protegidas de las frías corrientes oceánicas, ofrecen un ambiente térmico confortable, especialmente para las crías recién nacidas, que están más en riesgo en cuanto a las bajas temperaturas. Además, geográficamente hablando de la Bahía de Banderas, con sus aguas relativamente calmas y resguardadas de los fuertes vientos y oleajes, proporciona un refugio seguro contra los depredadores y las inclemencias del tiempo. La abundancia de alimento, compuesto principalmente por pequeños peces y krill, también contribuye a la salud de las ballenas durante su estancia en la bahía.

El avistamiento de ballenas se ha consolidado como una actividad turística de gran relevancia en Puerto Vallarta, generando importantes beneficios económicos y oportunidades de empleo para la comunidad local. Pero, es fundamental que esta actividad se gestione de manera responsable y sostenible, minimizando cualquier impacto negativo sobre las ballenas y su hábitat, y maximizando los beneficios para la población local. Para lograr este objetivo, es imprescindible establecer regulaciones gubernamentales claras y estrictas que controlan la actividad de avistamiento, capacitar adecuadamente a los operadores turísticos para que realicen su labor de manera segura y respetuosa con las ballenas, educar a los turistas sobre la importancia de la conservación marina y realizar un monitoreo constante de las poblaciones de ballenas y su entorno.

A pesar de los esfuerzos de conservación, la ballena jorobada enfrenta diversas amenazas en Puerto Vallarta, que ponen en riesgo su supervivencia a largo plazo. Entre estas amenazas, destacan la contaminación marina, el cambio climático, la pesca incidental, la colisión con embarcaciones y el ruido submarino. Para contrarrestar estos peligros, es necesario implementar estrategias integrales que aborden cada uno de estos problemas, tales como la reducción de la contaminación marina, la mitigación del cambio climático, la prevención de la pesca incidental, la promoción de la navegación segura y la limitación del ruido submarino.

En conclusión, la temporada de la ballena jorobada en Puerto Vallarta representa una oportunidad para conectar con la naturaleza, aprender sobre la vida marina y reflexionar sobre la importancia de la conservación de la biodiversidad. Proteger a estos magníficos animales y su hábitat es un deber y una inversión en el futuro económico y social de la región.



Why Mexico's Global Credibility Depends on the World Cup

By: Mati Robin

In 1982, Colombia lost the privilege of hosting World Cup because FIFA's demands exposed a gap between ambition and what the state could deliver. In 2026, Mexico is facing a different version of the same test: not whether it can host games, but whether it can guarantee security, logistics, and global confidence in a tournament that's bigger than ever.

Colombia was supposed to host the 1986 World Cup. It had secured the rights to the tournament in the 1970s, but in 1982 the Colombian government pulled out after admitting that it couldn't meet FIFA's requirements. In May of the following year, FIFA officially awarded the tournament to Mexico instead. That replacement decision is what most people forget. Mexico didn't get the World Cup because the tournament wanted a new host country, but because FIFA needed certainty. Mexico had already hosted in 1970; it had major stadiums and infrastructure, and it could step in quickly to save the tournament. Jump to today, and the scale is completely different. This World Cup is over one month long, co-hosted by three countries, and for the first time ever, it's 48 teams, meaning there's no room for error.

In 2026, Mexico isn't being tested the same way Colombia was all those years ago. The stadiums, host cities, and accommodations are set, but the real pressure is on whether Mexico can keep the tournament stable while security issues plague the country. Even though the World Cup is months away, the reaction to recent violence in Mexico matters. It's not just about what happens, but about how the world perceives the events.

Claudia Sheinbaum, Mexico's president, has already publicly stated that there is no risk for fans from around the world coming to Mexico for the tournament, which proves this is already part of the tournament's story. Gianni Infantino, FIFA's president, has stated his confidence in Mexico as a co-host, even as more and more headlines link violence in the country to the World Cup.

So, will the World Cup actually get pulled out of Mexico? The simple answer is probably not. The tournament is already set up for three countries, sixteen cities, and a nearly immovable schedule, but that doesn't make this any less serious for Mexico. If hosting is smooth, safe, and controlled, Mexico earns credibility on the biggest stage in the world. If cracks show and security looks unstable, then Mexico doesn't just receive a few negative headlines like it has for the past few years; it gets a reputation that outlives the tournament.

If Mexico succeeds in this test, it won't be because no security risks happen. Matches need to start on time, fans should be able to move safely, teams will travel smoothly, and the headlines will be strictly about football. However, this issue isn't something that a few people can handle but a nationwide effort. Broadcasters, sponsors, logistics coordinators, and other key players have to set up a near-perfect event to display the best version of Mexico to the world. If gaps start to show, every incident is one more hit on the entire country's reputation. This is why the tournament can't be treated like any other. A World Cup is the one opportunity Mexico has to teach everyone about its wonders and set up a bright future for itself.

What makes this test even more crucial for Mexico is how fast perception moves. Colombia's withdrawal happened at a time when news traveled slowly and narratives had time to shift. In 2026, one video can go viral and turn the global perspective into "Mexico is unsafe" overnight, even if it's one isolated incident that doesn't represent the entire nation. The country has to keep control at all times because how good the games are doesn't matter if the world begins to question if FIFA made a mistake.

FIFA's priorities are similar, but FIFA acts out of self-interest. It doesn't want a host country success story, but to protect the tournament's image by achieving a tournament that is stable, organized, and profitable. Pulling Mexico out is unlikely because it would be a public admission of bad planning. Despite this, if things start to look risky, FIFA can decide to tighten security protocols, restrict movement, and turn the event into something more controlled and less free at the expense of Mexico's reputation. While it would still co-host the tournament, it would feel like it's under emergency control, and the image would follow the country for long after the final whistle.

In 1982, Colombia didn't lose the World Cup because football failed, but because the gap between what FIFA needed and what the state could deliver was far too wide. In 2026, Mexico isn't facing the exact same problem, but it is facing the same kind of judgment. The tournament won't just be a stage for 48 countries to show their best football. Mexico will be on that same stage as a competitor and as a host, being graded not only on its footballing prowess, but on its coordination, stability, and control off the pitch.

If Mexico pulls it off, the World Cup becomes proof that the nation is more than just the negative headlines. If it doesn't, the damage won't be limited to one summer. By July 2026, Mexico's story won't be defined by the team's results, but by what it showed the world while hosting the show.



A Yes to a Crest: An Interview with Erin Healy

Maria Ibarra

When you think of a professional soccer player, you might imagine someone who grew up declaring, at five years old, that they would one day represent their country. Someone who mapped out every step, every camp, every contract. Erin Healy was never that kid.

Born and raised in San Diego, California, Erin grew up in a family where being active was simply just part of life. The youngest of three girls, now 24 years old, describes her childhood as energetic, supportive, and close-knit. Her sisters, both older, were her built-in best friends. “We’ve always gotten along super well,” she says, and even now, they wake up at 2 a.m. to stream her matches from across the world.



Sports were never forced in the Healy household. The rule was simple: try anything you want. And Erin did. She tried ballet, gymnastics, and other activities, but around eight or nine, she faced her first crossroads: commit to gymnastics pre-team or choose competitive soccer. Fortunately for her, she ended up choosing soccer, a decision she now looks back on with quiet gratitude.

Her earliest soccer memories are uncomplicated, with recreational teams like the White Huskies, volunteer dad coaches, and Saturdays that felt more like playdates than pressure. By nine, she joined her first competitive club, eventually moving through teams in San Diego, following coaches she trusted, and building friendships that extended far beyond the field. Then, high school soccer became one of the most joyful chapters of her life. At an all-girls private school, she played alongside her senior sister during her freshman year, winning state titles in Division III together. “Highschool was the most fun,” she admits. Her teammates were her closest friends, the field an extension of her social world, yet she insists she was never the stereotypical “soccer girl.” “I was always a girly pop,” she laughs. Athletic yes, but never boxed into one identity. Soccer was just something she loved, but it wasn’t her entire personality.

One of the most influential figures in her early career was her first competitive coach, Gabe. He made the sport creative, light, and fun. Winning and losing were secondary to expression. “He was perfect to start my little soccer career,” she reflects. To this day, when she returns to San Diego, she tries to meet up with him, a small reminder of where it all began.

Moving forward, if you had asked Erin in college what her future looked like, professional soccer would not have been the answer. She committed to play Division I soccer at Gonzaga University, drawn to a program she describes as “competitive yet underrated,” a team still carving out its identity. Gonzaga felt right, and not just for soccer, but for her life. She studied accounting and marketing, practical degrees with clear career pathways. In her mind, college soccer was the final stop: four years, a diploma, a job lined up at a public accounting firm, and then adulthood. In fact, there was a moment right before college when she nearly walked away from the sport altogether. Her summer after senior year, she left earlier for training camp, and while her high school friends were enjoying carefree vacations, she was grinding through isolating practices. “Maybe I don’t want to do this anymore,” she thought, but her mom gently encouraged her to try just for one year, at least, to honor her scholarship.

College soccer shaped her in ways she didn’t expect. Time management became survival. Balancing training, travel, classes, and a social life required discipline. Moving to Washington state without knowing anyone forced that independence. Soccer became both a responsibility and refuge, the place she could lose herself and block out everything else. But even then, she never imagined going pro.

After graduation, she believed she was done. Many of her friends were finishing their careers too, so that was what she felt was “supposed” to do. But coaches and mentors saw something in her she didn’t. “Why not stay for a year or two?” She could always go back to accounting in the future. And so, she did.

Her first professional experience came in Portugal’s first league. It wasn’t glamorous or lavish. Her team fought relegation all season. It was intense, uncertain, and eye-opening. Living abroad meant months without her family, without her support system, and the hardest part about it wasn’t the competition but the loneliness, the temporary nature of her friends and the realization that they might disappear from her life once her contract ended. Still, something shifted in Portugal. She realized she wanted more, maybe a stronger team or a different environment. She was certain though that if she wanted to keep playing, she was heading somewhere where English was a native language, just not the US, a different place that would feel both new and familiar at the same time. That’s how she landed in Australia.

Now based in Adelaide, South Australia, Erin describes the country as feeling like home with a twist. The summer weather, the coastal life, the sense that every day, even during a demanding season, holds a hint of vacation in the air, all made it feel like she was meant to be there. She loved her first year enough to return for a second, still weighing what comes next.

Professional life, she explains, is not as extravagant as it appears. Training runs from 8:00 a.m. to noon, starting with field sessions and then heading to the gym. Travel is constant, recovery time is limited, with no long off-seasons. But the emotional sacrifices to her are the heaviest. She has missed Christmas at home, family weddings, and high school reunions. Ordinary weekends with your friends involve a ball. “The physical toll is heavy, isolating, even if fans only see the 90 minutes under stadium lights.” But her grounding question remains simple: am I still having fun? And for now, she is.

As the years have gone by, there was one specific moment that made everything feel real. Through her mother, she secured Irish citizenship, making her eligible for a selection to the Republic of Ireland Women's National Soccer Team. She entered the player pool, a waiting space of possibility, where names are selected for camps and matches. One day, her name came up. She attended two camps where she played two matches. The most pivotal one though was the game against the United States National Women's Soccer Team. Although her team lost, that wasn't what mattered. Wearing Ireland's crest, hearing their anthem, standing on the field representing something bigger than herself, "That was my 'I did it' moment," she admits. It felt surreal yet like a natural step to take. Not fireworks, but fulfillment. A quiet confirmation that the little girl who chose soccer over gymnastics had stepped onto a path far greater than she imagined.

As of now, she's still in the national pool. Still chasing future call-ups and seasons in Australia. Still checking in with herself about how long this chapter will last. But if soccer were taken away tomorrow, she knows she would be okay. She has a degree and the career path waiting, but specially, a family who supports her unconditionally. So for now she continues, not because it was always a dream, but because somewhere along the way, the game that started as pure fun became something more. And maybe that's what makes her story different. Erin Healy did not grow up declaring she would be a professional athlete; she simply kept saying yes to the next step. And one day, that yes led her to a national jersey, a full stadium, and a quiet realization: she made it.



MIND

Matters



El Amor no es Verdad :Sino Psicología

El amor, aunque quieras creer, no es real. No existen las almas gemelas ni el amor a primera vista, a pesar de lo que te dicen las películas. Aunque muchos crean que el amor viene del corazón y es algo destinado, la realidad es mucho menos romántica de lo que piensas. El amor es una experiencia humana compleja construida psicológicamente a través de emociones, química cerebral y construcciones sociales. En términos simples, se trata de un proceso químico que ocurre en el cerebro, una combinación de hormonas y respuestas psicológicas que nos hacen interpretar ciertas sensaciones como el "amor". No es magia ni algo destinado, sino un proceso neurológico que se produce en el cerebro.

No importa lo que diga la poesía, el amor principalmente no viene del corazón, sino del cerebro. Para empezar, todo empieza con la percepción, el cerebro recibe estímulos visuales, auditivos y olfativos, los cuales le permiten identificar y diferenciar a las personas como únicos. Esto sucede en la corteza sensorial y el sistema límbico, en el cual el cerebro evalúa si otra persona podría ser de posible interés romántico. Específicamente esto sucede en la amígdala, la cual evalúa si algo es atractivo, familiar o relevante emocionalmente. Básicamente no se trata sobre el amor a primera vista ni una conexión especial, sino que un reconocimiento de estímulos que el cerebro asocia con algo seguro y positivo.

Luego de que la persona haya sido registrada como una opción de posible interés romántico, tu cerebro produce una cierta atracción hacia tal persona. Esta etapa se refiere a la activación del sistema de recompensa. Este consiste en que tu cerebro genere más emoción sobre dicha persona y te de más motivación para estar con ellos. Esto es debido a que asocia a la persona con tu bienestar emocional, interpretando su presencia como una recompensa. Esto provoca que se liberen sustancias de dopamina, las cuales te hacen sentir bien y generan una motivación, reforzando el deseo de estar con ellos. Cuanto más comodidad experimentes con la otra persona, mayor la atracción vas a sentir, ya que el cerebro busca constantemente aquello que lo hace sentir bien.

Con el tiempo, esta atracción puede convertirse en un apego emocional. Esto ocurre cuando el cerebro comienza a liberar oxitocina, o mejor conocida como la hormona del amor, es una sustancia que te ayuda a generar una conexión. Lo siguiente ocurre cuando el cerebro interpreta la atracción o tal conexión como algo de mayor importancia y dirige su atención hacia aquello. Esto causa que la serotonina, una sustancia en el cerebro que te hace sentirte tranquilo y estable, baje, lo cual lleva a que sea más difícil dejar de pensar en la otra persona. Al mismo tiempo la norepinefrina aumenta lo cual hace que estés más alerta, nervioso y hace que tengas emociones intensas. Por este cambio químico en el cerebro la atención se centra mayormente en esa persona. El cerebro entra en un estado en el cual la persona deseada se convierte en el centro de atención emocional y mental. Esta sensación de experiencia muchas veces es interpretada como tener un "amor profundo", aunque en realidad se trata sobre un estado temporal del cerebro en el que hay un cambio químico que causa obsesión.

Finalmente la mente no solo siente pero igualmente es mayormente influenciada por las construcciones sociales que se han formado hoy en día. Después de formar una atracción y apego a tal persona, la mente es influenciada por la cultura, las películas, la música y las ideas sociales sobre el amor verdadero. Esto causa que las personas empiezan a interpretar a estas sensaciones químicas como algo de significado especial. Esto hace que se crea una narrativa dentro de su mente en la cual ya no es una reacción química en el cerebro, pero simplemente es amor.

En conclusión, lo que llamamos amor no es un misterio inexplicable, sino una combinación de procesos químicos, respuestas psicológicas y construcciones sociales que el cerebro interpreta de manera especial. Desde la primera percepción hasta el apego y la narrativa que crea tu mente, cada etapa del enamoramiento tiene una explicación psicológica y emocional. Sin embargo, aunque el amor se pueda explicar a través de la psicología, saber esta explicación no le quita el valor a esta experiencia, y cada persona es libre para interpretar el amor como ellos deseen. Para algunos podría simplemente ser un proceso químico, pero para otros podría seguir siendo algo mágico y único. Al final el amor no solamente es como funciona el cerebro, sino que el sentido que cada quien quiera darle.

How Easy it is to Hate

A Psychology Paper.

By: William King.

Man is inherently a curious being. He shows an eagerness to experience new things, to learn about the world around him, but as much as curiosity is his nature, so is contradiction and fear. As much as people love the unfamiliar, they are afraid of it. It is for that reason that people fear the dark, and perhaps more shockingly why, more often than not, prejudice and hate is reignited in the hearts of people. It is an effect that lives in all of us, with irrational reasons to exist, because what is unfamiliar to us might be harmful to us, too.

The effect I'm talking about is the "mere-exposure" effect, or more precisely, the lack of it. According to the National Institute of Health, the mere-exposure effect is when "people evaluate a stimulus more positively after repeated exposure to that stimulus." In other words, familiarity causes preference. Conversely, when something lies outside a person's sense of normality, it may provoke discomfort or dislike. For example, people oftentimes are put off by intense or untraditional music (like death metal or experimental rock), not because they are inherently unpleasant, but because they are unfamiliar.

The absence of the mere-exposure effect in individuals can lead to significant repercussions. When someone grows up predominantly surrounded by a specific type of person, they are likely to favor that group as adults. A smaller-scale illustration of this can be found in a study conducted at Brandeis University, where white participants were exposed to various faces of Black and Asian individuals. The results revealed that participants tended to favor the faces of the racial group they encountered most frequently.

This Brandeis University experiment validated existing knowledge regarding own-race preference and the mere-exposure effect. Additionally, it highlighted a pressing societal concern: racial prejudice can partly stem from instinctive negative reactions to faces that differ from those to which individuals are accustomed. In other words, racism can arise simply from a lack of exposure to certain racial groups.

Recognizing the impact of our thoughts on interactions is essential for creating an equitable society. Our cognitive processes can shape unconscious biases that lead to discrimination. Through self-reflection and mindfulness, we can better control these biases and reduce prejudices against those who differ from us. While eliminating bias may be unrealistic, striving to minimize its influence will help foster empathy and respect for all people around you. This awareness is a societal responsibility that can promote a more inclusive environment and significant social change for everyone.

Shool

News



COPA SHARKS

BY LUNA OROZCO



The energy in ASPV is rising, getting ready for one of the most exciting soccer events of the year. Students from 7th through 12th grade will compete in several matches that require teamwork, sportsmanship, and make unforgettable moments on the field.

The tournament begins Thursday, February 26, featuring 12th grade against 10th grade on field 1, while 8th grade takes on 9th grade on field 2.

The action continues Friday, February 27, with 7th grade battling 12th grade, and 8th grade competing against 11th grade.

On Monday, March 2, 9th grade meets 10th grade, and 7th grade plays against 8th grade.

Tuesday, March 3, 7th grade faces 9th grade and 10th grade plays against 8th grade.

Wednesday, March 4, 11th grade will be playing against 9th grade, followed by 7th grade versus 10th grade.

On Thursday, March 5, 12th grade competes against 8th grade, while 7th grade challenges 11th grade.

The final regular season match up took place Friday, March 6, with 9th grade facing 12th grade and 10th grade playing 11th grade.

Tuesday, March 10, 12th grade takes on 11th grade to finalize the matches.

After this the excitement continues Wednesday, March 11, with a special repechage match. The teachers will compete against the 4th place team from the regular matches. The winner of this game will advance to semifinal 1, adding a twist to the tournament.

The semifinals will take place over two days. On Thursday, March 12, the 1st place team will face the winner of the repechage match. Then on Friday, March 13, the 2nd place team will go up against the 3rd place team.

The tournament ends on Monday, March 16. First, the losers of the semifinals will compete for 3rd place. Finally the champions will be decided in the Grand Final, where the winners of the Semifinal 1 and Semifinal 2 will face off for the school title.

This tournament is more than just a competition, it's a celebration of school spirit, teamwork, and healthy rivalry. It's an event where students, teachers and families are encouraged to come out and support their teams. With skill, practice, determination and a great cheer, this year's tournament will be one to remember.

NHS article

By: Cloe Ellsworth

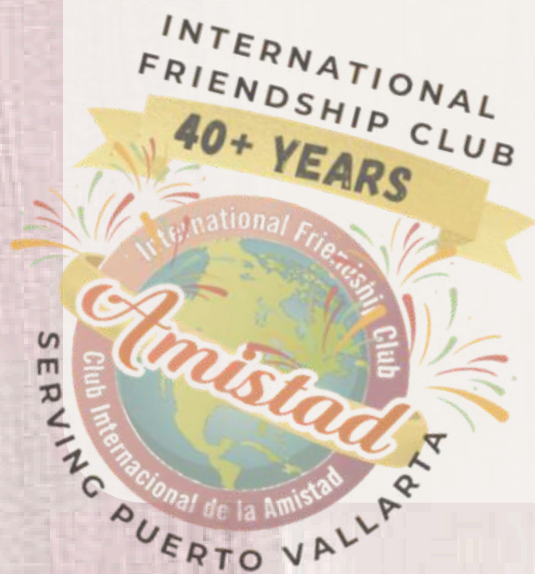


On Saturday, the 15th of February, our NHS team attended a gathering organised by the International Friendship Group, where various service teams presented how they contribute to the well-being of Vallarta.

At the conference, people from all around Vallarta stopped by to learn how we help our community. We were especially proud to mention Brain Boosters, a project that started last year and has become a permanent part of ASPV. Inspired by the tourism-driven economy in Vallarta, a group of students decided to found Brain Boosters, a weekly English class for kids throughout the community who might not have a chance to learn it otherwise. Through games, classes, and readings, Brain Boosters has strengthened language skills in Vallarta, fostered students' confidence, and expanded their academic and professional opportunities.

We also mentioned other impressive programs such as Kids in Science, which focuses on teaching children how fun science can be through educational experiments, and other service trips taken to Yelapa and Vallarta Cares that directly impacted the community.

We also met many possible donors and talked about future partnerships with other service groups. Having the opportunity to meet several passionate individuals who care so much about helping others was inspirational, to say the least. Overall, the gathering left us with a feeling of gratitude and appreciation for all the work everyone has put into our community, reminding us of how impactful positive change can be when everyone collaborates.





Library News

By: Kara Heiniger

February has been a busy month in our ASPV library as new books come in and more books go out into the hands of students and staff. Shelves have highlighted romance novels for Valentine's Day and works by Black authors for Black History Month. I spoke with classes about some of our nonfiction works that can help them dive deeper into the topics they're studying. Students from Health class visited the library to explore the wellbeing benefits of reading.

Within all this, a clear theme stands out: books provide a window to the world. In the *Cascarrabias* article "How Easy It is to Hate" by William King, he points out that being unfamiliar with something can lead to fear and bias. Books offer us a way to learn about people different from us, whether they're from another country, different socioeconomic background, or just a walk of life that isn't the same as our own. Our books for Black History Month highlight some racial differences, but there's even more to discover on our shelves. Building empathy is important for our wellbeing, giving us the understanding we need for interpersonal relationships and eliminating the fear we have of others who we may feel are different from us. Perhaps reading their stories can show us how we're not so different after all.





Our new books cover a wide range of genres, topics, settings, and authors. You'll find books that reflect your own experiences, helping you understand your own path in life. You'll also find books that teach you something new. No matter what you're looking for, stop by the library to nurture your mind.

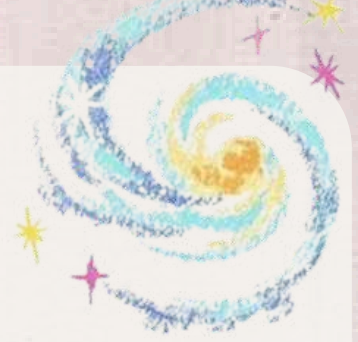
*Follow the QR code to
browse our catalog with
this year's new books!*





La No Oculto del Profesor

Berenice Reyes



Habilidades ocultas:

Pintura y fotografía, no sé cómo, pero hay algo de habilidad ahí.

Trabajos raros antes de dar clase:

Trabajé por 3 meses en el área de juguetes de un Soriana para poder subsistir mientras estudiaba la especialidad. Lo disfruté muchísimo!

Talentos que nadie imagina: En una etapa deportiva, fui montañista y nadadora por al menos 3 años.

Gustos sorprendentes:

Me encanta el ballet clásico y el baile urbano, aún no he ido a ninguna clase, pero en mi siguiente vida seré bailarina profesional.

Cómo eran en preparatoria:

En la prepa era tremendamente ñoña, jugaba basquetbol todo el tiempo y mis amigos siempre me hacían participar en sketches cómicos escolares.



Charis

What where you like in highshcool?

In high school, I was both a sports and a theatre kid. I loved volleyball, but my main passion was (and still is) performing, whether in glee club or in school musicals, where I got to sing, dance, and act. (My volleyball coach and musical theatre director weren't always thrilled about sharing me.)



Kyriel Casillas:

Cuando era niña, solía pasar los veranos en la casa de mis abuelos y hacía las siguientes actividades. Ese era mi lugar favorito.

a) con pago:

Recogida de huevos en una granja con 300 gallinas ponedoras.

Desgranaba mazorcas.

Cosechaba limones, aguacates y guayabas y los vendía en la puerta de la casa.

b) Como responsabilidad familiar no pagada:

Cuidaba a mis primitos y les contaba cuentos desde antes de cumplir 10 años.

Alimentaba a las ardillas, gatos y hasta a una mona verde a la que le gustaba arrullar a los pollitos y perritos bebés.

c) Para jugar:

Cocinaba con mi abuelita y ayudaba a mi abuelito a regar el jardín.

Me subía al tronco de un árbol de ciruelas.

Jugaba con arena de construcción y pintura en polvo en la fabriquita de loseta hidráulica de mis abuelitos.

Corría, hacía casitas con sábanas, jugábamos a las escondidillas y hacíamos desastre en toda la casa.

Bordaba, tejía y hacía manualidades con mi tía.

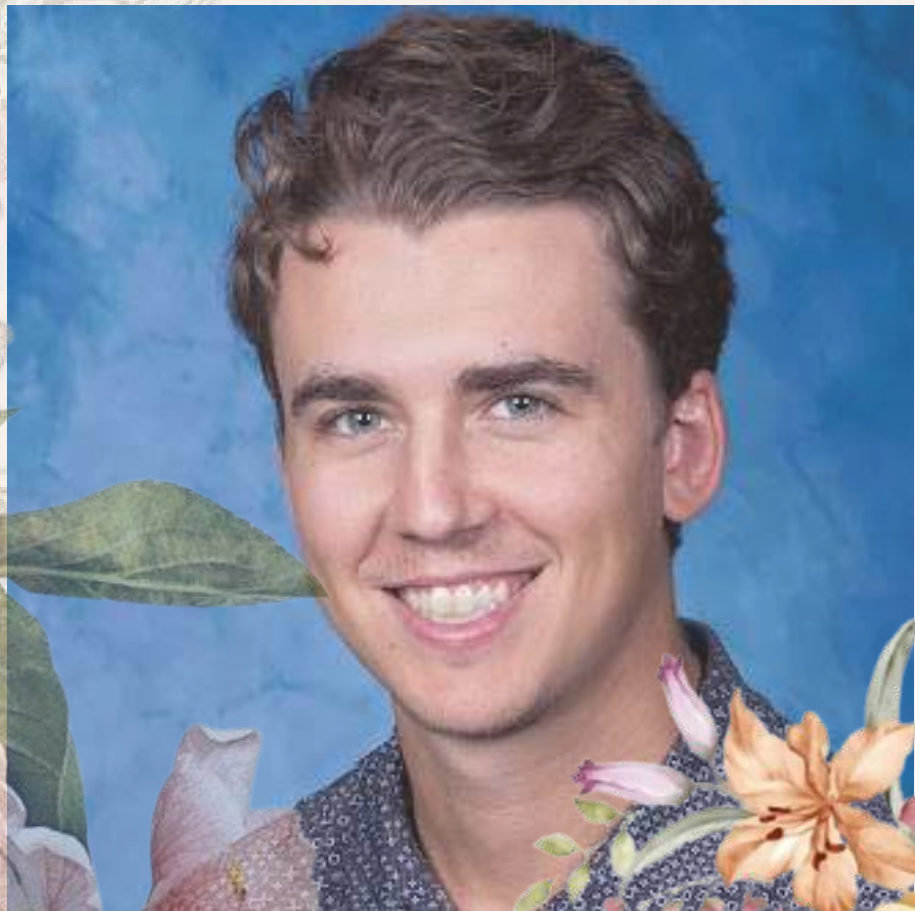
Capturábamos renacuajos a orillas del lago y los echábamos a una pileta para ver cómo se transformaban en sapos y ranas. El exterior de la casa estuvo lleno de batracios por mucho tiempo.

d) Cuando me volví adulta, le leía en voz alta a mi abuelita y recordábamos a mi abuelito o veíamos la televisión juntas.

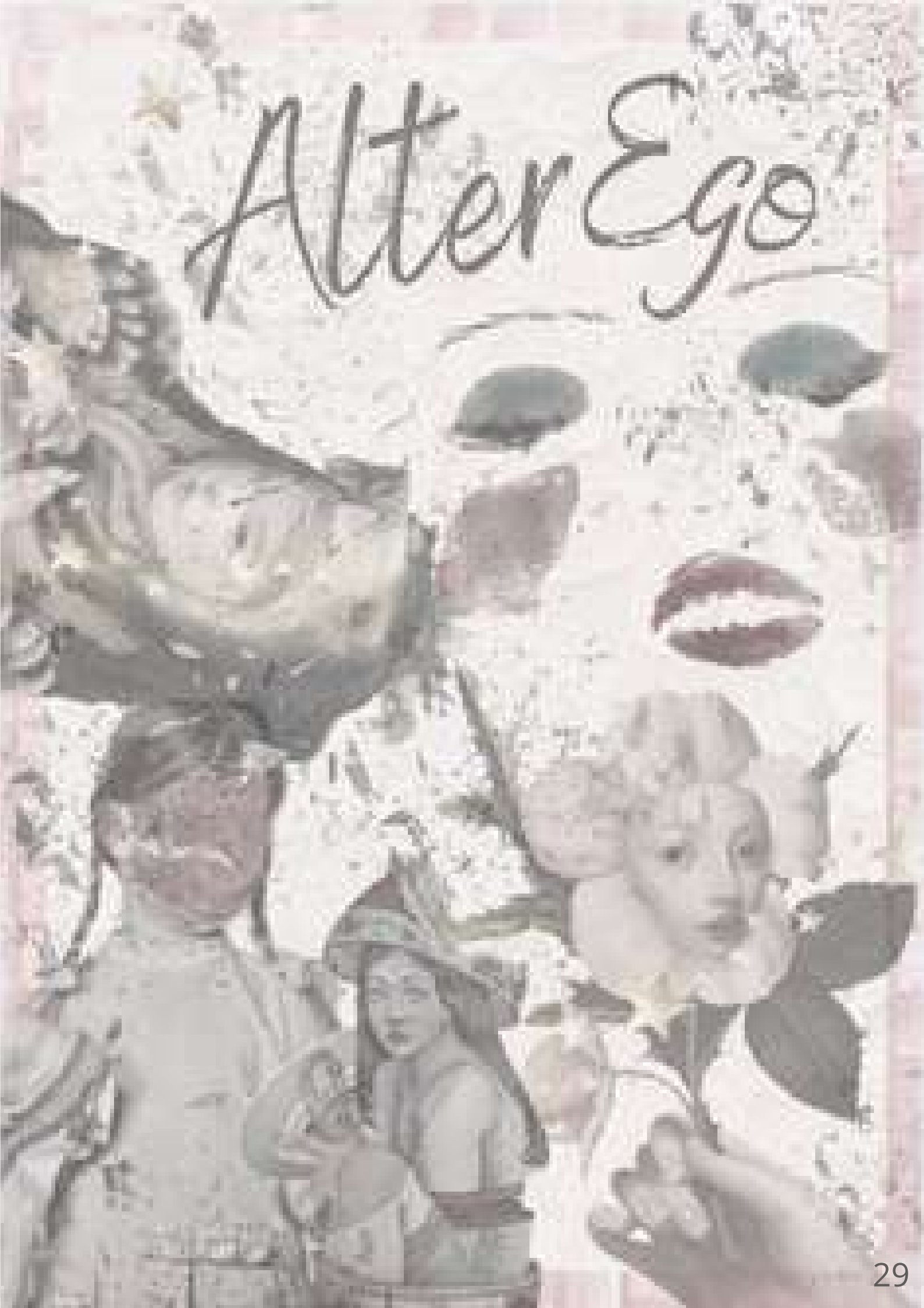


John Hatfield

I worked at Dairy Queen when I was 15, I worked as a pizza delivery driver when I was 16, and then I worked in a deli until I was 22. No surprising hobbies really. I love watching movies: Lord of the Rings are probably my favourites. In class, I find that I say "Stop yapping" and "chop chop" quite a lot.



Alter Ego



Fábula de los dos changuitos y el mapache

Por: Valentina Avelar

Había una vez dos changuitos a los que les gustaba pasearse por un andador, reían y gozaban como si el día no se fuera a acabar. Pero llegó un día en el que un mapache tenía un objeto muy particular: era cuadrado y la pantalla no dejaba de cambiar.

Pitequito el changuito se hizo adicto a esta pantalla con brillo, dejó de gozar y jugar. El otro changuito, Perenganito, le empezó a tomar el tiempo de cuánto lo veía, y así, se lo quitaba cada vez más rápido, hasta que lo dejó.

Moraleja:

Sé consciente de cuánto tiempo pasas en las redes sociales, para que así termines con la adicción.



EL BOSQUE DE LAS SERPIENTES

Por: Verónica Peña

En el gran y verde bosque, las serpientes normalmente cambian de piel al menos cuatro veces al año. Pero últimamente, entre ellas, está en tendencia cambiarla al menos una vez al día. Todas las mañanas, las serpientes se mudan a una nueva piel con diferentes texturas, colores y estilos, dependiendo de lo que esté de moda ese día. Lentamente, el gran bosque se llena de los restos de las pieles que va dejando cada una, y poco a poco el verde va desapareciendo al ser cubierto por residuos.

No es necesario cambiar de estilo todo el tiempo, pero cuidar el medio ambiente sí lo es, porque perjudicar el mundo en el que vivimos por el capricho de estar “a la moda” no vale la pena.



POR GOLOZO ME CAÍ AL POZO

Por: Román Covarrubias

Había una vez un burro que no era normal,
caminaba en dos patas y era algo especial.
El burro se llamaba Pepe y le gustaba mucho comprar.
Pepe tenía de todo y aun así quería más.

En su celular su tiempo le gustaba pasar.
Pepe el burro no dejaba de comprar.
Día tras día la casa de compras se llenaba más y más.
Pobre Pepe, no entendía que tenía que parar.

Su amigo Jorge el caballo le reveló
un consejo, que Pepe al inicio ignoró
Jorge le dijo: "amigo, debes pensar:
-¿de verdad lo necesito o solo quiero comprar?-"

De hoy en adelante voy a pensar.
Si sigo comprando, la casa va a explotar.
Pepe el burro dijo con emoción:
"¡Ya me liberé de esta adicción!"

Un consejo que vale oro para combatir esa necesidad de comprar impulsivamente en línea es pensar si en verdad lo necesitas y para que lo necesitas. Si quieres comprar ropa, piensa: "¿En verdad necesito más ropa a pesar de que tengo el clóset lleno?" "¡NO!" Ese es el tipo de razonamiento que debes de usar.



The background of the page is a collage of various school-related items. At the top, there's a yellow ribbon award that says "Best Mom". To its right is a large blue ribbon award that says "Wrote a Book". Below these, there's a pink ribbon award that says "Kissed my inner child" and a purple ribbon award that says "Good Teacher". In the center, there's a green ribbon award that says "Wrote a Dress". The collage also includes several books, pencils, a ruler, and a protractor.

AL SEÑOR MENTIROSO POWERSCHOOL

Por: Leo Hernández

Detrás de las puertas azules que examino a diario,
viven mis calificaciones.

Un fenómeno que me hace dudar de mí mismo,
y que tiene un valor inmenso para mi vida.

Estudio para satisfacerlo, señor,
pero a veces siento que no estoy aprendiendo.

Trabajo para usted, pero mi conocimiento se perjudica,
quizás la relación que tengo con usted vale menos.

Tener una relación con el señor conocimiento,
eso es más importante que con usted.

Me ayudaría a fomentar las dos relaciones,
ya que con conocimiento, llegan las buenas notas.

El estrés se desvanece con el aprendizaje,
no me agobio tanto con estudiar,
si el tema ya reside en mi mente.

De ahora en adelante lo pondré en practica,
el conocimiento se vuelve parte de mí para siempre,
no solo por un tiempo.

Moraleja:

Quien se enfoca en las calificaciones, no aprende realmente





Wanting What Isn't Mine

By: Malaika Cawood

I stumbled out of my dingy one-bedroom apartment on the lower East Side of New York city, clinging to my pounding head and the clutter in my arms. As I made my way through my doorframe I stumbled over a dozen envelopes with "Last Notice" stamped in bright red ink on the front.

The brittle winter air pulled me out of my drowsy state as soon as I stepped outside, and I quickly realized that what I needed the most at this moment was a large, hot coffee. I waved my arm frantically at a cab that seemed to be completely unaware of my existence, speeding past me and drenching me with grimy water from a nearby puddle in doing so. Great.

Instead of ruminating on this, I gathered my wits, wiping my face and deciding that I would walk the ten blocks to my favorite coffee shop. The city streets were bustling with people despite it being early morning, so I weaved my way through them with the sort of expertise you gain from living in this city. Then, when I was about two blocks away from my destination, I saw something that made me stop dead in my tracks. In between two buildings, on a 10 foot tall billboard, there she was. Her big, bright smile and pristine face suspended in the air for the entire city to see.

Unbelievable. This was the winter clothing campaign she had stolen right from my hands a couple months ago. And now here she was, looking effortlessly elegant as ever and taunting me with her flashy grin. I felt my face scrunch into an unrecognizable expression as I balled my fists and suppressed the rage building in the pit of my stomach. I lingered in the middle of the sidewalk for a few moments, unable to believe what I was seeing.

Eventually, I managed to pull myself together and dragged my feet to my destination. As soon as I stepped inside and got my coffee, I retreated to a small table near the back. I sipped the scalding liquid in an attempt to calm the growing tension behind my eyes but soon realized that it was in vain. I hadn't eaten a full meal in nearly two weeks. Which sounds awful when I say it, but rent was due soon, and all the casting directors had turned me away and told me to come back once I dropped ten pounds.

To be fair, I had long understood that the modelling world comes with its own set of challenges and a deeply toxic culture, so I was always fully aware of the stakes. I let out a sigh and pulled out my phone in an attempt to distract myself from the gnawing pit in my stomach and the pounding in my head. Almost as if by instinct, I opened up Instagram. Big mistake.

Of course the first thing I saw was her post from last week, in which she was lounging on some luxurious yacht in the tiniest bikini- vintage Dior, of course- and propped up next to Hollywood's newest up-and-coming heartthrob. I felt the bile rise in my throat.

I reserved a burning hatred for her that I had never felt for anyone else. Her and her stupid flawless body and flowing blond hair that seemed to always fall perfectly on her shoulders. My jaw remained clenched, even as I set my phone down and settled on staring at the wall ahead of me for entertainment. Suddenly, as if my day couldn't get any worse, I heard the entire coffee shop clamor at a sudden arrival. I didn't have to look up to figure out who it was. I heard her before I saw her. Or rather, her endless swarm of paparazzi and devoted fans constantly at her heels.

As she walked in, everyone climbed on top of each other to reach her, asking for pictures and autographs or professing their undying love for her. When I finally did look up, I was taken aback. She seemed more gorgeous in person, if that was even possible.



The guy in her insta post was tightly wrapped around her arm, seemingly afraid that if he let go for even a second she would vanish into thin air. She humbly obliged her fan's indulgences for a few minutes and then made her way to the till to ask for a coffee.

"On the house", the guy behind the bar said, flashing a goofy grin.

She thanked him sheepishly, but her boyfriend's expression sour. Then, I saw the barista write his phone number on the cup before handing it to her, his gaze lingering a little too long as she made her way to a nearby table with her boyfriend. I couldn't believe it. How could someone just glide through life like this, not having to do anything and still being adored by the masses and having everything handed to her? Something in my chest twisted, sharp and familiar.

I felt the pang of envy burrow itself deeper into my ribs and make its home there. It had followed me all morning: down the stairs, through the city streets, and into this cafe. But if I was being honest with myself, it had been following me far longer than that.

And now, it whispered hateful quips in my ear, urging me to look at her again and scrutinize her for any flaws I could find. Upon closer inspection, I realized that she wasn't as untouchable as she made herself out to be. Her skin, flawless on every magazine cover, looked dull and lifeless under her makeup, and the faint shadows settling just beneath her eyes threatened to reveal themselves from underneath the layers of concealer. Her smile faltered each time another phone was shoved in her face, and another fan scampered off without so much as a thank you. Every move she made seemed to be rehearsed and methodical.

I noticed that when nobody was looking, even if just for a moment, her eyes reflected a quiet sadness and her shoulders let themselves sag for a second. Despite this, envy nudged me harder, whispering that even this tired version of her was triumphant over me. Then I saw her make eye contact with me, and a quiet recognition settled between us.

She didn't make her way over to me but I could tell she knew who I was. She looked almost apologetic. I thought back to how many magazine covers, advertisements, campaigns, and runway shows she had ripped from my hands. I tightened my grip on my cup, feeling the heat sear into my hands and ground me in reality. Then, almost as suddenly as she arrived, she was gone in a flurry of coats, cameras, and admiration. The door shut behind her, and the air around me seemed to grow a little lighter.

No one noticed me sitting there, no one ever did.

I finished the last few drops of coffee, now bitter and lukewarm. I stood, envy trailing just behind me like some twisted shadow I could never shake. Outside, daylight had sharpened the city and the billboard still loomed in place, shining brightly against the pale winter sky. I faltered for a moment, looking at my reflection in a storefront window and flickering back up to the billboard.

Envy tightened its grip, but I kept walking, letting it follow me because I knew it always would.

TAL VEZ MAÑANA

Por: Rodrigo Sierra

Era un viernes común y corriente, Mateo se encontraba en su clásico escritorio de escuela, fingiendo prestar atención a la maestra. El joven estudiante miraba de reojo el reloj del aula, se moría por salir lo antes posible de aquella jaula disfrazada con pizarrones y colores llamativos. Era su último año, a pocos meses de graduarse, pero él no parecía importarle, se le hacía una flojera estudiar, trabajar o siquiera escribir apuntes. Y allí se encontraba él, jugando con el bolígrafo en lugar de escribir. De repente, el timbre sonó, Mateo se estaba preparando para guardar sus libros empolvados en su mochila, pero la maestra los detuvo.

—Jóvenes, como ya saben, estamos a poco tiempo de acabar este año escolar.

Todos aplaudieron y celebraron, pero la maestra los interrumpió.

—Pero, como tal vez unos ya sepan, tendremos sus exámenes de último año, para por fin terminar esta etapa de preparatoria y pasar a la universidad. -- La maestra hablaba sin ilusión, para ella, era la décima vez que daba ese mismo discurso en su vida.

Todos empezaron a escribir en su computadora, anotando recordatorios del gran examen. Mateo, en cambio, ni se inmutó, solo estaba estirado en su silla, sin preocupaciones. La maestra los dejó salir, no sin antes decirles a todos.

—Más les vale estudiar, este examen podrá definir sus vidas—La oración se quedó flotando en el aire del húmedo salón, todos se estremecieron, Mateo solo se puso sus audífonos y se dirigió a un lugar tranquilo del patio escolar para comer.

Mateo llegó a un rincón solitario, justo debajo de un árbol, un lugar donde nadie lo podía molestar, hablar o juzgar. El joven no vio a ninguno de sus compañeros, solo estaban los de primero y segundo de prepa. Mateo imaginó que todos estaban en el aula de la materia más temida, matemáticas. Los ojos le pesaban al estudiante, poco a poco, su cuello se apoyó en el tronco del árbol, cayendo en un sueño profundo.

El joven estudiante escuchó el silbido del viento en aquel sueño, el silbido se volvía cada vez más fuerte, al punto de empujarlo. Mateo logró escuchar una voz, la voz era de un hombre sereno pero directo.

—¿De verdad es así cómo quieres vivir, desconectado, con unos audífonos puestos y ajeno a tu futuro?

El joven quería responder, aclararle que no le importaba ser un engranaje más en una máquina gigante, pero en cambio, el viento, antes leves corrientes, ahora ráfagas, se lo llevó volando.

Mateo despertó de golpe, su corazón por alguna razón latía a mil por hora. Él no vio a nadie en el patio, ni siquiera a los de primero y segundo. Rápidamente, se quitó los audífonos y se dirigió a la salida antes de quedarse encerrado todo el fin de semana en el colegio.

Al momento en que Mateo llegó a la salida, se encontró con el portero de la escuela a punto de cerrar, el estudiante rápidamente le avisó que no cerrará. Cuando él salió, se quedó estático por un momento, las palabras de esa voz en el sueño resonaban en su mente “es así cómo quieres vivir”. Él tuvo una idea, no lo pensó, su cuerpo actuó, Mateo agarró de su mochila un papel con la dirección de una cafetería, la cual era propiedad de un gran amigo de su padre.

Cuando Mateo llegó a la cafetería, primero se detuvo antes de cruzar por la puerta, no sabía si esa decisión era la correcta. “Mi padre estaría orgulloso, mi madre se extrañaría.” Pensó antes de abrir la puerta.

Mateo llegó a la barra, él cajero lo atendió. —Bienvenido a la cafetería olivo ¿que desea ordenar?

Mateo le entregó la hoja de su padre.

—Vengo a buscar un empleo, puede ser de lo que sea, solo quiero hacer algo ahora, no en el futuro.

—Buena elección... ahorita busco a mi supervisora.

El estudiante esperó por un rato, él estaba algo ansioso, pero su visión era más poderosa.

Justo en eso, un hombre de tal vez unos veintitantos años le agarró el hombro. Mateo se quedó confundido, y hasta sintió pánico por un momento, pero al ver al individuo, todo ese miedo se fue, no sin antes dejarle una sensación de extrañez. El adulto tenía una taza de café en la mano.

—¡Hola!—se presentó cordialmente el señor extendiendo la mano.

Mateo respondió al saludo, más que nada para no quedar mal.

—Debes de estar buscando trabajo aquí ¿cierto?—preguntó con una risa bromista mientras buscaba algo en su maletín.

—Si—respondió Mateo preocupado, pues él no vio al hombre antes de hablar con el cajero— ¿Cómo sabes?

El sujeto dijo en tono de broma.

—Yo lo escucho todo aquí.

Mateo se quedó pensando por un momento, tiempo en el cual el único sonido que había era el del refrigerador. Luego lo comprendió.

—Ahh, usted debe ser el gerente ¿cierto?

—No exactamente, soy el subgerente, osea su mano derecha—Luego se rascó la barbilla para posteriormente inferir—pero técnicamente, por ahora soy el gerente, pues el amigo de tu padre se fue a un viaje de negocios en Chicago.

El subgerente, al ver la expresión de Mateo, le explicó.

—Conozco a tu padre, pues mi jefe me ha hablado mucho de él y de ti. Ellos son amigos desde la primaria.

Solo entonces, Mateo dejó de desconfiar. —En fin ¿estás listo para tu entrevista?—dijo tomando un poco de su café.

Mateo se quedó callado por un par de segundos, pero afirmó seguro de sí.

—¿Por qué quieres tanto este empleo?

—Quiero ganar dinero—dijo dudando de su motivo.

El subgerente le dirigió una mirada incrédula. Mateo se encorvó y bajó la cabeza.

—La verdad es que no sé, tuve un extraño sueño que me hizo cuestionarme mi futuro—Suspiró—¿Sabes? Estoy a punto de reprobador la mayoría de mis materias, y quiero tener un plan B en caso de que me expulsen.

El hombre puso los codos en la mesa, pensando en algo que decirle al joven.

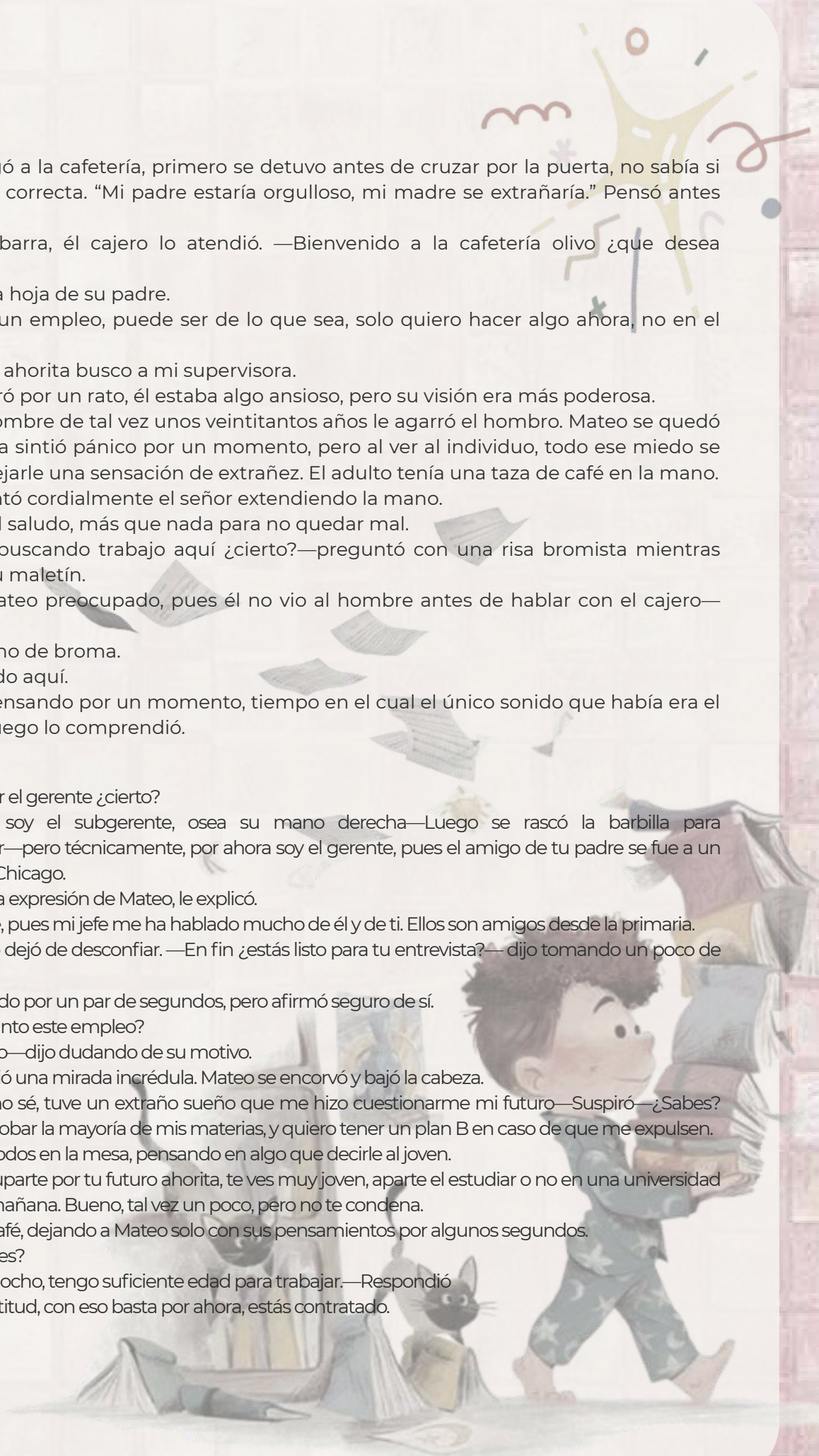
—No deberías preocuparte por tu futuro ahorita, te ves muy joven, aparte el estudiar o no en una universidad buena no define tú mañana. Bueno, tal vez un poco, pero no te condena.

El señor terminó su café, dejando a Mateo solo con sus pensamientos por algunos segundos.

—¿Cuántos años tienes?

—Diecisiete, casi dieciocho, tengo suficiente edad para trabajar.—Respondió

—¡Perfecto! Tienes actitud, con eso basta por ahora, estás contratado.





Un incómodo silencio llenó la cafetería, después, el subgerente, ahora jefe de Mateo, le ordenó a empezar a trapear el local.

Mateo pareció darse cuenta de algo, pero cuando volteó hacía su jefe, él ya se había marchado a su oficina.

Pasaron casi dos horas, sus padres ya sabían de su nuevo empleo, pues él se los contó. Cabe destacar que Mateo tenía razón, su padre estaba orgulloso, pero su madre sospechaba algo, él lo notó en su voz en aquel audio de whatsapp

El jefe llamó a Mateo a su oficina, Mateo pensó que ya había acabado su labor.

—Saca los libros de tu mochila, Mateo.

Mateo estaba confundido, pero con tal de no trabajar, accedió.

—¿Cuáles son las materias que más te cuestan?—Preguntó abriendo la agenda de Mateo, página por página.

El joven se quedó pasmado.

—¿Pero para que hacer la tarea de escuela en el trabajo?—preguntó algo incómodo.

—Me dijiste que vas a reprobarte tus materias—dijo en tono amable—Y quiero ayudar a mi nuevo empleado.

—Está bien...—Accedió Mateo de mala gana

—Escuché que los estudiantes de tu edad tendrán un examen para la universidad ¿cuánto te falta para ese examen?

—Unos meses, creo que tres meses. No entiendo por qué nos avisan desde ahora ¿para qué preocuparse si eso pasará en el futuro?

Su jefe solo revisaba meticulosamente su agenda, para luego decir.

—Está bien, empecemos por matemáticas....

Los meses pasaron, Mateo cada vez le entendía más a sus materias, todos los días, cinco horas al día, Mateo visitaba la cafetería para trabajar, su jefe a veces le ayudaba a estudiar lo que él no entendía, pero si lo guiaba en sus estudios y sobre todo, le hizo ver a Mateo sí tenía futuro. Durante aquel tiempo, Mateo hizo amigos en la cafetería, los cuáles tenían vidas muy similares a la de Mateo, pero todos tenían un problema principal en común, el miedo a la incertidumbre del futuro.

La mayoría de sus compañeros no hablaban del jefe, Mateo ni se sabía su nombre y siempre se le olvidaba preguntarle. Durante estos meses, el joven se encontró con varios topes, pues había días en los que su cuerpo y mente llegaban al límite por los trabajos escolares, estudiar y aparte trabajar.

El estudiante ya había acumulado una gran cantidad de dinero, era una cantidad que definitivamente no hubiera conseguido de seguir con su antigua rutina. A Mateo siempre le daban propinas, por alguna razón, los clientes se llevaban bien con él. Pero no sabía qué hacer con el dinero aún, pensaba en guardarlo para los gastos de su universidad.

Mateo se desvelaba seguido para entender los temas que antes no entendía, pero sabía que tenía avance.

Cuando Mateo llegó, se encontró con uno de sus amigos.

—¿Qué haces aquí amigo? según yo hoy no trabajabas—preguntó algo confundido el amigo.

Mateo trató de recuperar el aire, pues salió corriendo de la preparatoria en cuanto pudo.

—¿Dónde está el jefe?

—¿Qué?



Pero el chico ni se inmutó, “voy a demostrarle que si soy capaz” pensó.

Poco a poco fueron llegando sus compañeros, algunos con visibles ojeras en la cara y cansancio. La maestra fue repartiendo los exámenes, con cada alumno a un metro de distancia. Mateo sintió un vuelco en el estómago cuando el examen estaba frente a sus ojos, las preguntas eran largas y complicadas, no por nada el examen duraba tres horas. Lo peor, era que ese examen contenía muchas áreas: Matemáticas, lectura, inglés, un poco de geografía y ciencia. Por un momento, Mateo se paralizó, su mente daba vueltas como una rueda de carro, el tic tac del reloj lo iba a volver loco de seguir sonando en pleno silencio del salón, pero el estudiante decidió empezar a trabajar.

Cada pregunta contestada era como subir la montaña, cada etapa nueva era más difícil que la anterior. Lo más difícil del examen, fue un problema de cálculo, se tenían que hacer varios procesos tardados los cuales eran muy confusos. Así pasó Mateo las siguientes tres horas, sufriendo con la dificultad del examen y contestando poco a poco las preguntas sin estar seguro de esas respuestas. Pero había algo diferente, en el pasado, Mateo hubiera soltado el lápiz en la primera pregunta, pero ahora, daba lo mejor de sí para cada respuesta, sin importar lo difícil que estuviera. Sin darse cuenta, Mateo había llegado a la última pregunta del examen, la sorpresa lo inundó cuando no encontró más preguntas del otro lado. Por un lado, sintió un fuerte temor, temor de no saber si estaba correcto, temor a descubrir que él era el mismo Mateo de hace tres meses, aquel Mateo el cual no le daba importancia a nada, aquel joven que solo quería vivir y ya, sin metas y sin visión a futuro.

Nuestro protagonista lo pensó. Pero al final se armó de valor y fue a entregar su examen, no sin antes verificar minuciosamente cada respuesta. Con solo diez minutos restantes, Mateo decidió dormirse un rato, aquel reto lo había cansado de sobremanera. El tic tac del reloj seguía sonando de fondo, pero cada vez se desvanecía más, hasta no sonar más. Mateo tenía una duda,

—¿Está diciéndome que hay chance de que apruebe?

—Tu aprobaste desde que decidiste no rendirte, el número en ese examen es solo un plus. Pero si, yo creo que aprobaras.

—Gracias—agradeció el joven antes de salir de aquel salón. Mateo tenía una duda,

—¿Está diciéndome que hay chance de que apruebe?

—Tu aprobaste desde que decidiste no rendirte, el número en ese examen es solo un plus. Pero si, yo creo que aprobaras.

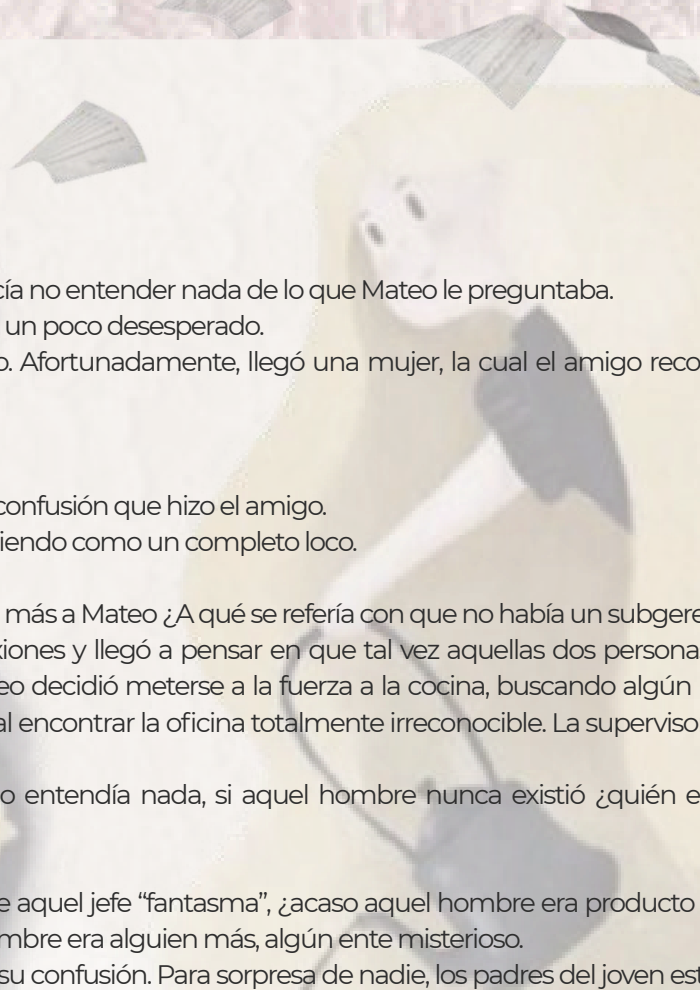
—Gracias—agradeció el joven antes de salir de aquel salón. Mateo salió de la preparatoria lo antes posible, afortunadamente, por el tema de los exámenes la hora de salida se programó más temprano. El estudiante, llegó a la cafetería Olivo lo más rápido que pudo, listo para contarle a su jefe su experiencia en aquel examen. Cada cuadra que caminaba le daba más ilusión, ilusión de mostrarle a su jefe su mejora. Cuando Mateo llegó, se encontró con uno de sus amigos.

—¿Qué haces aquí amigo? según yo hoy no trabajabas—preguntó algo confundido el amigo.

Mateo trató de recuperar el aire, pues salió corriendo de la preparatoria en cuanto pudo.

—¿Dónde está el jefe?

—¿Qué?



El amigo estaba muy desconcertado, parecía no entender nada de lo que Mateo le preguntaba.

—¡Sí! El jefe, el subgerente de aquí.—Insistió un poco desesperado.

El amigo cada vez estaba más confundido. Afortunadamente, llegó una mujer, la cual el amigo reconoció como la supervisora.

—Hola Mateo ¿pasa algo?

—Quiero saber donde esta el subgerente.

La supervisora hizo la misma expresión de confusión que hizo el amigo.

Mateo ya estaba desesperado, él estaba luciendo como un completo loco.

—Mateo...no hay un subgerente.

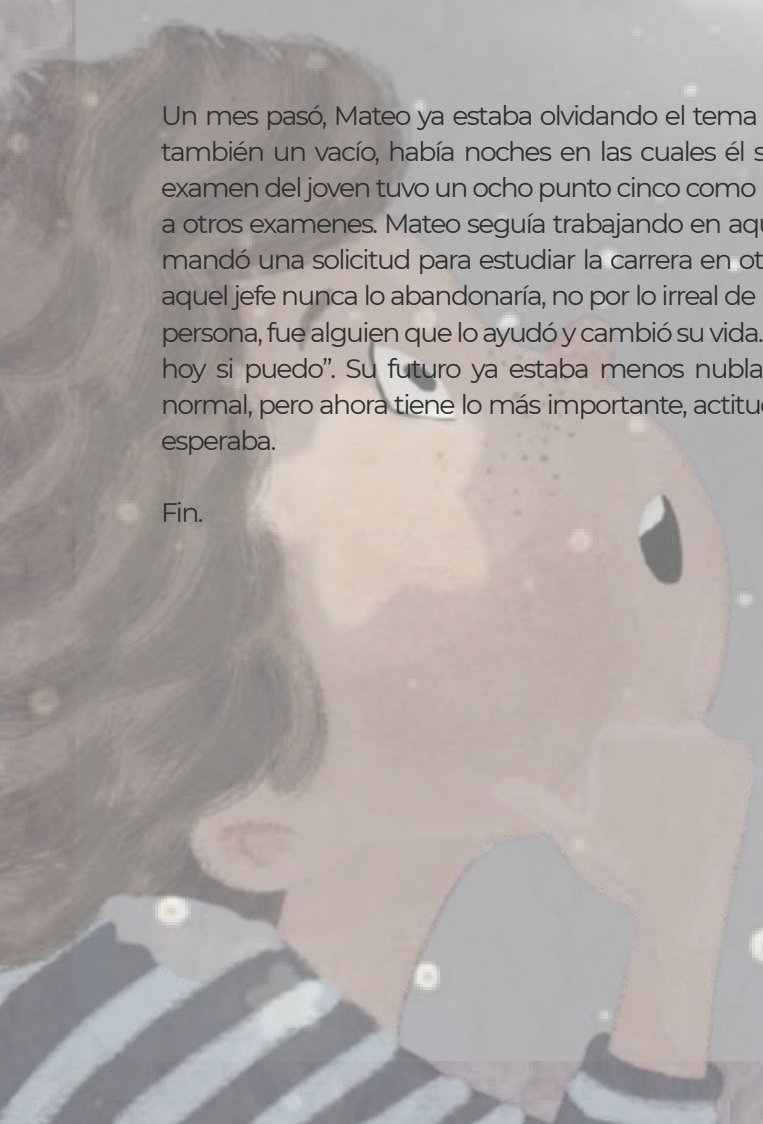
Las palabras de la mujer aturdieron todavía más a Mateo ¿A qué se refería con que no había un subgerente? Pensó Mateo. Pero empezó a hacer conexiones y llegó a pensar en que tal vez aquellas dos personas que tenía enfrente estaban en lo correcto. Mateo decidió meterse a la fuerza a la cocina, buscando algún rastro del jefe, pero quedó totalmente pasmado al encontrar la oficina totalmente irreconocible. La supervisora y el amigo de Mateo lo alcanzaron.

—Mateo... ¿Qué está pasando? El joven no entendía nada, si aquel hombre nunca existió ¿quién era? O porque solo Mateo supo de él.

Sin más opción, Mateo regresó a casa.

Durante el camino, el joven reflexionó sobre aquel jefe “fantasma”, ¿acaso aquel hombre era producto de su imaginación? O tal vez aquel misterioso hombre era alguien más, algún ente misterioso.

Al llegar a casa, los padres de Mateo vieron su confusión. Para sorpresa de nadie, los padres del joven estaban igual de confundidos que él.



Un mes pasó, Mateo ya estaba olvidando el tema del jefe. El recordarlo daba cierto grado de tristeza, pero también un vacío, había noches en las cuales él se quedaba viendo a la luna, pensando en que pasó. El examen del joven tuvo un ocho punto cinco como resultado, no era perfecto, pero si había mucha diferencia a otros exámenes. Mateo seguía trabajando en aquella cafetería, pero pronto dejaría aquel empleo, pues él mandó una solicitud para estudiar la carrera en otro estado, solicitud la cual fue aceptada. La memoria de aquel jefe nunca lo abandonaría, no por lo irreal de la situación, sino porque lo que sea que haya sido aquella persona, fue alguien que lo ayudó y cambió su vida. Antes decía “Lo haré mañana”, pero ahora él dice “lo haré hoy si puedo”. Su futuro ya estaba menos nublado que antes, pero seguía habiendo incertidumbre, lo normal, pero ahora tiene lo más importante, actitud a mejorar. Mateo solo sabía una cosa, un gran futuro lo esperaba.

Fin.

For Our Daughters. Our Children. Our Lives

By: Polette Lopéz

For our daughters,
our children,
our lives,
we hold the signs high in the sky,
until justice answers our relentless cries.

The future watches us,
with wide, unblinking eyes,
trusting we'll build a freedom,
for those who can't rise.

We march because daughters,
shouldn't inherit battles
their mothers already bled for,
battles that should've been history by now.

We march to break the cycle,
to make sure our daughters have options,
choices born from freedom,
to decide what happens to their own
bodies.

Somewhere in the crowd,
a little girl on her mother's shoulders,
sees a sea of raised hands,
and sees a world being remade for her.

No man sitting behind a desk,
passing laws about lives he'll never bear,
should decide what happens in a uterus
he will never carry,
while chanting "your body, our choice"
without a care.

Because we are not marching for
permission,
we march for the right to our bodies with
ambition,
for choices generations have yearned,
for a future defined on our own terms.

We rise against a world that silenced
us,
taking back the power denied to us,
so every voice once hushed,
learns to rise again, unbound and
uncrushed.

Because this fight is older than we are,
our daughters watching the battles we
defended,
refusing to let the next generation,
inherent a struggle we can finally end.
This is our cry,
our movement,
our promise,
that women's freedom is undisputed.
For the signs may tarnish away,
but our spirits will stay,
all for a brighter future to behold,
and a world where freedom stands
bold.

For our daughters,
our children,
our lives,
for every woman out there,
who deserves the right to her own
body,
who should live the freedom she
should embody.



Women's Rights: MANKIND'S MARIONETTE

By: Pato Villareal

I was tied by my arms and legs
By a prison of words
I was told to smile and never cry
I was told to be pretty and not speak loud
I was told to stay quiet and never answer back
I was bound by a name that I didn't choose
A tag wrapped around me that said who i was
It said that i should be sexy and hot
But its weird because then they called me a "whore"
And the tag then wrote the destiny of my soul
It talked about rape and the desire of men
How they hold my hands
and make me theirs
How they broke me
and make me less
How they beat me up
and called me names
How my screams and cries didn't help
It only make it funnier to them or so they said
I was thrown to the streets once they were done
Like a piece of garbage with no use anymore
And when I got to my house no one realize I was gone
I told my mom what was going on
she ran away from the room
With tears falling off of her face, maybe from pain
Or from shame but I knew at that moment
That it was something we shared
And we went to the police and they only asked for my
name
They took notes on my weight
And added me on a list
Months went by and i was no longer a girl
There was a bulge on my belly
A constant reminder of my hell
The men who took my everything easily ran away
And even when they caught them they were treated
with respect
With respect?
They took away my virginity
Made people call me impure
Took away my friends

Because they couldn't handle the truth
But they got the decency of a court
And lawyer that had their back
They asked me if i liked it
And said it was my fault
My clothes were too revealing
But I was only wearing my primary
uniform
They said i looked so grown
And that its my fault for having make up
on
The guys agree and the women looked
down
I was afraid and no one was on my side
At the end they went to jail
And I had a baby by my side
I became a mom
But my babies grandma wasn't around
I heard him cry
Every day and every night
And the memories of that day kept me
on the edge
Of life
Until that day or maybe night
When my son became a man
And I had too many wines
I decided to end it all.

LAST BREATH

By: Summer Payet

I can't breathe
I feel the concrete under my skin
My airway is blocked
My voice is cracking
I've always been loud but you've taken it away

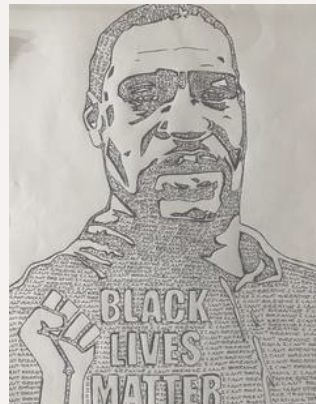
Stop i cant breathe
I can't breathe

How am I supposed to get in your police car?
How can you expect me to move with all this weight
crushing me?
The weight of your knee, digging into my neck
The weight of your broken system, built against me
The weight of your hatred
My heart can't beat

It took four of you to silence me
I felt your hatred four times
How many others have you hurt?
When you shoved me in the car i felt the walls closing in
My freedom and my dignity shrunk four times

My mama doesn't deserve this
She worked too hard and put up with too much
She put up with too many people that were exactly like
you
She can't breathe

Before you see my eyes your weapon is drawn
You saw the colour of my skin and decided to aim
I'm not a monster
But you look at me with disgust
I've harboured no violent intentions yet you shove me to
the floor like a beast
Is this what you've been taught, that we're all barbaric?
That we're animals that need to be caged
Locked up so tightly that
we can't breathe



I'm one of you but its something you
cant see
because you go blind after seeing the
colour of my skin
Colour makes you blind
You ignore the beating heart, the
wheezing breaths
You ignore those who could save me
Their pleas are useless because you've
made up your mind
You can breathe and you'll do
everything in your power
To punish me and my mama
For living in this country
For walking in your streets
For not looking like you
Maybe you're scared
But I promise I'm more afraid than you
ever will be
I can't breathe
Eric Garner couldn't breathe
The system never said his name
The system didn't protect him
And it will never protect me
But it will protect you just as is has
shielded thousands of others
And it will keep hurting millions of
people
Loud in their laughter
Silent in their suffering
WE can't breathe
I can't breathe
I can't...

The Last Goodbye

By: Pedro Ahumada

If I could just see my kid one more time,
I didn't know I was going to be gone,
For working hard they had to pull out some cuffs?
Maybe that's what the US wants

If I could just see my kid one more time,
Would Trump accept me back?
Or would another wall rise between us,
A line on a map that broke my life in half?
If I could just see my kid one more time,
I'd hold them tight so they'd never forget
That I crossed borders for their future,
Not to become a number in someone's report.
If I could just see my kid one more time,
Will the other millions be able to come back?
Will the hardworking people be able to regain their job?,
Will the US become what it once was?
But If I could just see my kid one more time,
I'd whisper that I'm still fighting,
That love survives detention walls,
And that our goodbye is not the end.



IMMIGRATION: THE CRIME OF LIVING

By: Pato Villarreal.

I came to the country of opportunities with nothing but some dirty clothes and a dream, but what is a dream? It depends on who you ask. Here on this side of the world, kids dream about sports cars, millions of dollars, the new iphone, or something as nice as eliminating world hunger. That is a good and noble dream that people from my country cannot have. When you have to cry silently while praying until you fall asleep, begging so that you don't die on the crumbles of a building after being hit by an enemy bomb; dreaming becomes a privilege. You can't think of something as noble as ending world hunger. How can you dream of mercy, and peace, when all you've seen is cruelty and war? Where I was born, kids dreamed that one day they could have a meal, nothing like bread beans and rice. That wasn't possible even in our imagination, just one of those was enough. Some dreamed of seeing their parents and brothers come back from war, but I learned when I was little that war will take them. They can either get the mercy of dying in battle or they are punished with living, because people don't come back from war, they become a shell of what they once were, like trying to remember a distant memory, or building a puzzle with missing pieces. And you may ask for my dream. I wanted more than just a meal or a dad, my dream is to eat sugar. I heard that it is something sweet, like the candies my grandma made before the war, but even sweeter! I can't remember the last time I tried something sweet, and I can't ask my grandma because I learned that the dead can't talk, or maybe they simply don't want to.

When I came to the United States I cried, because my prayers were listened to. It was the most amazing and wonderful place in the world. There were no dead people in the streets, other adults did not carry guns while pointing at the women and children. I was hungry, starving really, but I couldn't care about my belly when my heart was pumping so fast. I had the best sleep of my life, I was able to sleep on the ground, with no bombs or alarms that made me fear my life, and a restaurant owner even invited me to have a meal. I had eggs, bacon, and coffee, and there were little bags on the table. After I asked the owner what it was, he told me that it was sugar, I couldn't believe it was free! I opened the packages, and ate as much as I could, tears ran down my face, maybe because I fulfilled my dream, or maybe because my belly was full. It didn't matter because I finally felt the warmth of peace and love. That small act of kindness was more than enough to change how I viewed the world. I asked for a job, and although the owner refused at first, I offered to work for half as everyone else. He then happily accepted, and that was enough for me.

I'm a good man, and I had to run from a war I didn't ask for, from parents I didn't want, and all for a dream that wasn't mine. I dreamed of trying sugar but is that really what my heart wanted? Would I want that if I didn't have parents that reminded me everyday how much of a mistake my mere existence was, if living through the night wasn't something likely to happen then maybe my dreams could be bigger, then maybe I could have been more. It is easy to blame the people for their misfortunes, but we can only be as great as what we believe, and in a world where you can't even believe that you'll live to see another day, you are bound to be small.

Peace is an odd feeling. People don't realize the beauty that lies in the peace of everyday life. But I learned that peace and happiness are not together. I was an object of laughter, maybe for my accent, or my name, or my appearance. I was prepared for this but I can't help being ashamed. I'm still a man and I still have pride. Although we all were born from the same earth and destined to return to earth once our time is over, people decide to put importance into the only things I didn't choose.

Whether you want it or not, time doesn't stop for anyone, and one thing that time has taught me is that it doesn't heal your pain or your past. It allows you to live with it. To unconsciously wake up in the kitchen of the house you've always wanted with a woman that you can finally call the love of your life, and kids that will never know the pain of war. While you are washing the dishes or driving to work there is something that reminds you of that memory of the past, a flash, something that quickly passes by, and you manage to remember it with tears in your eyes, but also with a smile because the same pain that kept you up every night has managed to become an old story from the past. Or so I thought.

One day I was robbed, but not from my wallet or phone but from my freedom and my rights. Masked men were screaming and attacking me, pulling me into a truck with no explanation. They worked for ICE and they didn't ask for my papers or my name. They made the decision only based on my face. They acted like the criminals that they are supposed to take. Tased me, Punishment that I did not deserve. They put me in a cell with other inmates whose only crime was to share my race. They asked for papers while hitting me. They have more respect for rapists and killers than a random guy trying to go by the day. How can I afford papers? When they are worth more than a year worth of work? How can I have them with me when they take almost a decade to come? They took away my legal rights, put me into a truck and sent me away, throwing me away in the nearest country that allowed me there, and once again on step one, but this time was different. I was pushed away from a country of "peace." I was kidnapped away from a family that I loved, and that distant memory came back and I thought of my dad, and how he was right. Maybe my existence was a crime and every breathing moment was a punishment for that.



creative

writing

the direction
of your true
heart

Un día anodino.

Por: Ángela C.

—Ahhh...—suspiré.

No podía haber persona más desinteresada en este momento en el mundo que yo. Estaba sentada en una silla de fierro tan incómoda que ya me estaba empezando a punzar la columna. Me encontraba dentro de un cuarto encerrado y sin ventanas, lleno de personas que no cesaban de hacer ruido, pero para este tiempo parecía que mi mente ya lo había bloqueado.

De repente percibí que alguien me llamaba:

—Señorita, ¿usted qué opina?

Me tardé en contestar; la verdad que, para este punto, ya nada me importaba.

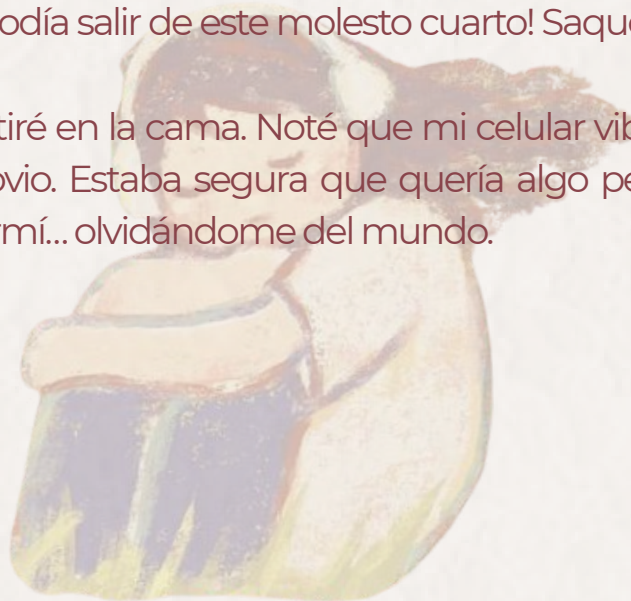
—Pues... no sé —respondí finalmente.

Percibí las miradas sobre mí ante mi falta de respuesta; mi cabeza estaba inclinada y mi atención estaba en el celular. Noté que me había llegado una notificación: era de mi hermano. No lo había visto en mucho tiempo, podría decir que como dos años, más o menos.

Su mensaje era solo una respuesta al mío, agradecía mi felicitación y me corregía que él no había cumplido años el dieciséis sino que hace dos semanas atrás, el cuatro de enero. No tenía ganas de responderle pero finalmente le conteste: "Ok".

Al levantar mi cabeza, el cuarto estaba casi vacío, quedaban cinco personas en el lugar y se estaban despidiendo. Volteé a ver la hora: eran las seis y media de la tarde. Había perdido la noción del tiempo y ni siquiera me acordaba a qué hora había entrado. ¡Por fin podía salir de este molesto cuarto! Saqué mis audífonos y puse música.

Al llegar a mi departamento me tiré en la cama. Noté que mi celular vibraba con una llamada de Liam, mi novio. Estaba segura que quería algo pero le colgué apagué el celular y me dormí... olvidándome del mundo.



La noche en que la Luna desvaneci6.

Tristera

Todo empez6 una fría noche de 2016, la noche que rompi6 todo en mí. Esa noche en que la luna desvaneci6, todo se torn6 azul; todos se escondieron y muchos se mostraron valientes para proteger a los que ya no podían más. Esa luna era la luz de muchos y la seguridad de otros. Por cada ventana que pasabas, ella estaba presente, haciéndote sonreír con un meneo de cola, un ladrido, una lamida.

Esa luna que tanto extrañaron y extrañan no es más ni menos que mi perrita, Luna. Ese día no fue nuestro único susto; ya había tiempos en que ella nos sacaba uno, más de 4 veces, yendo al veterinario, pero seguía con nosotros porque sabía que la necesitábamos, y se iba apagando poco a poco para no espantarnos y protegernos.

Luna era una perrita muy cariñosa; siempre estaba con alguien a su lado y nadie podía evitar acariciarla. Ella era mi mejor amiga. Cuando pasaba un mal día, ella estaba ahí. Era mi favorita y yo la suya, todo el tiempo, todos los días; no había ni un día en el que no me la pasara con ella por lo menos un ratito. Ella era la luz de mi vida, la que me hacía feliz. Y su pérdida fue cuando todo mi corazón se destruy6.

Recuerdo perfectamente esa noche, como si hubiera pasado ayer. Yo tenía alrededor de 7 años, y para mí a ella le sobraban muchos años más conmigo, pero no, ella ya se tenía que ir, la necesitaban allá arriba.

Ya todos estábamos en pijama, mi papá seguía en el trabajo, eran como las 6. Mi mamá estaba en el baño, mi hermano en nuestro cuarto, y yo estaba o en nuestro cuarto o en la sala. Nadie le estaba prestando atención a Luna, pero de la nada se empezaron a escuchar ruidos extraños. Nadie sabía de dónde venían, pero cuando volteé a ver a Luna encontré la fuente del sonido.

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Luna, mi Luna, estaba en su cama sufriendo. No sabía qué hacer; lo único que pensé fue en gritar por mi mamá. Mi hermano escuch6 mis gritos de angustia y miedo y lleg6 corriendo. Al presenciar esa escena tan traumática, él también comenz6 a gritar. Mi mamá, conmovida por el grito, sali6 del baño lo más rápido que pudo. Cuando reaccion6 a lo que estaba pasando, ella agarr6 a Luna y todos salimos corriendo con pijama, sin zapatos, tristes, con miedo. Llegamos corriendo al elevador, donde nos topamos con una vecina, quien nos ayud6 con Luna y nos acompañ6 al veterinario.

En el carro, mi mamá iba manejando; la vecina, con Luna en brazos; mi hermano y yo, agarrándole la mano a mi mamá mientras llorábamos mares.

Al llegar al veterinario, nos dieron la noticia de que Luna va a estar en 'cuarentena' por 7 o más días. Ella estaba en una caja de vidrio muy pequeña, viviendo de un tubo que le daba aire a los pulmones.



Amor

Es una hermosa y cálida tarde de verano. Los rayos del sol se reflejan suavemente en mi recámara, dejando un rastro de sombras doradas. Mientras me alisto para ir a la playa con todos mis hijos y nietos, no puedo evitar detenerme frente al espejo. Las facciones que una vez definían mi rostro delicado ahora muestran únicamente el paso del tiempo. Cada risa, cada lágrima, cada sonrisa, hoy viven dentro de mí. El tiempo es el ladrón de mi pasado; sin embargo, hay algo que no ha logrado quitarme. Con el paso de los años, mi corazón ha crecido con cada hijo, con cada nieto.

Al terminar de arreglarme, salgo del cuarto en busca de mi nieto más pequeño, Samuel. Camino por cada rincón de la casa, pero sigo sin poder encontrarlo. En eso, escucho risas que vienen desde mi patio. Son mis nietos, lo mejor que me ha pasado. Al salir para comenzar nuestra caminata hacia la playa, Samuel toma mi mano con fuerza. No me importaba que el camino fuera largo. Las brillantes y bellas flores a mi alrededor hicieron que los minutos se sintieran como segundos. Todo estaba tan hermoso, tan lleno de vida.

Cuando menos me lo esperaba, mis pies tocaron la arena. Se sentía suave, y en eso, un olor fresco y salado se presentó. El sonido de las olas rompiendo en la orilla del mar es una melodía para mis oídos. De repente, escuché los gritos y pasos de alguien que se acercaba hacia mí. Es Samuel. Con cada paso que daba yo podía sentir la conexión entre nosotros crecer. Al llegar conmigo, mi nieto me dio el abrazo más grande y exclamó:

—¡Te amo!

Un calor comenzó a recorrer mi panza, pecho y luego se fue hacia mis brazos. Nunca me había sentido tan apreciada, vista y amada por alguien. Juntos, nos sentamos para poder admirar los colores del cielo mientras atardecía. Poco a poco, mis hijos y nietos comienzan a sentarse. Unos simplemente estaban a un lado mío y otros tomaban de mi mano. Mientras platico con mi hijo mayor, el resto de mis nietos se acomodan aún más cerca de mí, con el deseo de que cada uno de ellos pudiera recibir un abrazo.

—Qué hermoso atardecer —dijo mi hijo mayor.

Una sonrisa se apoderó de mi cara. Yo sabía que lo que estaba viviendo iba a ser una de esas memorias que nunca se olvidan. Podría pasar horas en esa playa porque en ese momento me di cuenta de que mi vida estaba completa. Antes, el amor que sentía vivía dentro de mí. Ahora, lo veo en mis hijos y mis nietos.

Sin Aviso

Por Sofia Silva

Sorpresa siempre ha sido así: llega sin avisar y se coloca en frente de mí con una confianza que solo ella se atreve a tener. Aquella tarde la sentí sin verla antes, escondida atrás de la puerta, conteniendo la risa como una amiga que no sabe guardar secretos. Cuando la puerta se abrió, Sorpresa saltó hacia mí con los brazos bien abiertos y gritó mi nombre, empujándome directo al centro del cuarto.

El espacio se volvió borroso. Globos flotando, confeti en el piso, carteles coloridos y caras conocidas mirándome con expectación. Pero Sorpresa no me soltaba, me tomaba del brazo y me susurraba al oído todo lo que debía sentir: emoción en el pecho, calor en la cara, un nudo en la garganta. Quería moverme, reír, abrazar a todos, pero Sorpresa también sabe congelarte. Me dejo ahí, inmóvil, recordando que no todas las emociones se entienden al instante.

Mientras observaba a las personas que más quiero, note cuánto tiempo y cuidado había puesto en ese momento. Sorpresa me empujó suavemente hacia ellos, como diciendo que no tenía que reaccionar perfecto, solo sentir. Y aunque la felicidad me abrumaba y las lágrimas amenazaban con salir, entendí que Sorpresa no venía a confundirme, sino a recordarme algo simple: soy querida, incluso cuando no sé cómo expresarlo.



Harvard, a reality, not just a passion

By Grace Kenzy

I woke up gasping for air because I thought I missed the deadline. Turns out, I didn't; it was just a bad dream. Today is the day I submit my college applications for my dream college, Harvard. Words couldn't describe how long I've waited for this day. Ever since I was 13, I knew Harvard was the college I wanted to attend. Its beautiful campus and rigorous courses inspire me to work hard every day, reminding me that all of my efforts in school will finally pay off one day. I've spent the past four years of my life analyzing every trait of students who've gotten into Harvard, joining charities, student councils, and even shelters. I often find myself lurking through Tiktoks and Instagram posts of past Harvard alumni, daydreaming about becoming one of them.

It may seem obsessive, but my mother always told me to work for what I'm most passionate about, so I listened. Sometimes when the stress of thinking I may not get in consumes me. I like to imagine the crisp air of Boston blowing into my hair, a book in my hand, and the soft spoken words of intelligence lingering throughout campus. It's all I've ever dreamed of. It's almost funny in a way, just thinking about it gives me more butterflies than the time I went on the tallest roller coaster in the world.

I've never felt so passionate about something other than Harvard, and that's what brings me here today, staring down at the submit button in black italics beaming from my computer screen. Attached above is my submission essay and grades... what's going to determine the next seven years of my life. I take a deep breath, my heart racing, and my mom's hand patting my shoulders.

"Press it sweetie" my mom whispers as my computer mouse lingers over the submit button. "You know your results will be great, you've worked hard for this," she says as I press the button.

A squeal slips out from the opening of my lips, and I hug my mom crossing my fingers in hopes for the best. My mom suggests I stay off of my computer for the next few months while we wait for my pending results, so I shut my computer and lay it out on the counter where I can't easily access it. I turn on my notifications for Gmail so that I can check to see my results as soon as they get sent out.

Exactly two and a half months later, I am sitting in my living room when I hear a notification from my computer. I get up rapidly to find that it's a notification from Gmail. I immediately head to the kitchen. My palms are sweating as I open my email to find a message from the Harvard Admissions Office stating, "Open to see results".

My mom appears around the corner, hovering over me and the computer screen. Although I'm nervous, I'm smiling ear to ear and eager as ever to open this email. I've waited so many years for this moment, and it feels surreal to think that it's actually happening. I look over at my mom, whose hand is covering her mouth that's curved in an upward nervous smile, and click onto the email.

"Congratulations on your acceptance to Harvard School of Law! We are pleased to have you attending this upcoming fall of 2027." I let out a squeal, jumping up and down out of excitement. My mom picks me up, spinning me in the air. "I got in," I shrieked. In this moment I see my whole future in front of me, all of the anticipation and hard work has paid off. I am going to be a Harvard law student, and no one will ever be able to call me obsessive for working towards my dreams because they are now a reality.

Después de alrededor de 1 semana, nos dieron la noticia de que ya no podían hacer nada para salvar a Luna. Era su hora de irse; la necesitaban más allá arriba que aquí abajo. Así que mi mamá y mi papá tomaron la decisión de dejarla ir y poner fin a su sufrimiento. Mi hermano y yo nos despedimos y después de eso, todo fue un borrón. Me habían llevado a la casa de una amiga para intentar contentarme, pero yo no podía hacer nada, solo lloraba y lloraba. Extrañaba, extraño, a mi mejor amiga; estaba deprimida, no quería hacer nada, solo llorar y no parar hasta que otra vez vea a esa cara que tanto extrañaba, hasta que llegue a tocar su pelo, hasta que llegue a abrazarla. Me pregunto constantemente por qué, por qué se la habían llevado. ¿Por qué a ella? Yo la necesitaba; la necesito.

Hoy entiendo que Luna no se fue del todo. Sigue siendo esa luna que aparece en las noches frías cuando más la necesito, la que me acompaña en silencio cuando me siento triste, la que me alumbra con la poca luz que ofrece. Con el tiempo aprendí que amar también significa dejar ir, y aunque su ausencia dolió y sigue doliéndome, me dejó un amor que no se apaga, no termina.

Luna fue quien me enseñó el amor incondicional y la pérdida, incluso antes de que yo pudiera entender qué eran. Su ausencia marcó una parte de mi vida que nunca volvió a ser igual, pero también me ayudó a convertirme en lo que soy hoy: una persona que ama profundamente, incondicionalmente. Aunque ya no esté conmigo, vive en cada recuerdo, en cada noche que miro a la luna y pienso en ella. La luna fue, es y siempre será parte del cielo, aunque a veces se esconda y se desvanezca. Gracias a Luna, aprendí a amar sin miedo, a sentir profundamente y a guardar recuerdos que nunca se irán.



The Story of Joy



By: Athenea Estrada

Once upon a time, there existed a place on Earth where free spirits could wander through the crevices in between the tangible life and the spiritual, dancing back and forth. They were as present as a hush of breath threading through your hair on a windy day, a sudden shiver climbing your arms when snow first touches skin, small reminders that something unseen was still alive. In that place, emotions were not hidden inside chests or locked behind ribs, they floated freely, glowing like lanterns only the heart could see.

Among those drifting lights was a feeling called Happiness. She moved through places in the form of a tall, slender young woman, her presence as gentle and as unmistakable as warmth after cold. Those who encountered her rarely spoke her full name, and instead called her Joy, for that was what lingered long after she passed.

To be near her was to experience something entirely new. It felt as though, before her, the sensation had never existed at all, as if the world had been waiting for her arrival to discover it. People struggled to describe what she gave them, searching for a word that could hold the lightness in their chests and ease their breaths. When none could be found they borrowed her name instead. Happiness, they called it, unsure whether the feeling had been named after the women, or the women after the feeling. And while the world began to take root, spreading from heart to heart, she continued on her way, unaware that something far larger than herself was beginning to form in her wake.

Joy, like many, had a best friend called Melancholy.

Melancholy wore her smoky brown hair like a lingering shadow, her skin pale as winter light, and her grey eyes helped a quiet depth that neither warmed or softened, only endured. Melancholy did not glow, and she did not drift like the others, nor did she shimmer when hearts brushed against her. She remained close to the ground, taking the shape of a woman whose presence was felt more than it was seen, soft, steady, and unhurried. Where Joy was warmth after cold, Melancholy was the cool that followed, the quiet that settled once the light had passed.

Therefore, it was Melancholy who first spoke of it.

They were sitting at the edge of a place joy had lingered too long, the air was still warm with laughter that no longer belonged to anyone. Joy stood nearby, watching the light she had left behind, unaware that some of it no longer clung to her.

"You shouldn't stay," Melancholy said, her voice low and even, as if she were commenting on the weather.

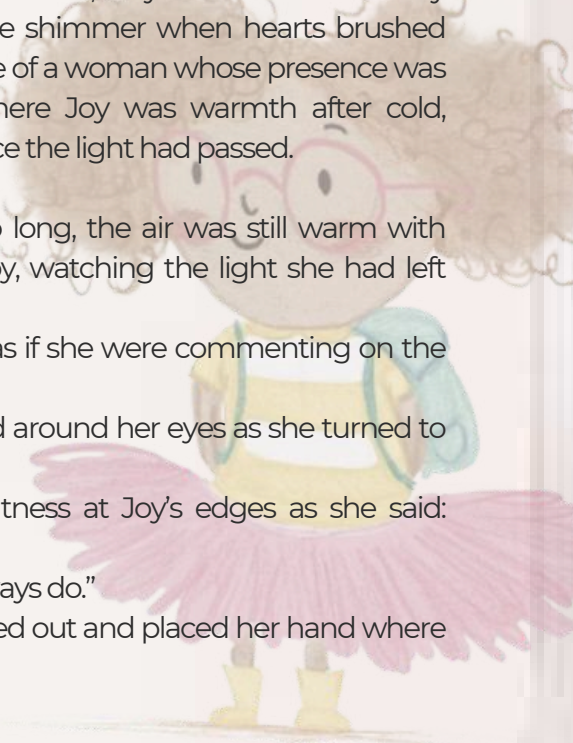
Joy turned surprise. "Why not?" her golden curly locks bounced around her eyes as she turned to look at her friend.

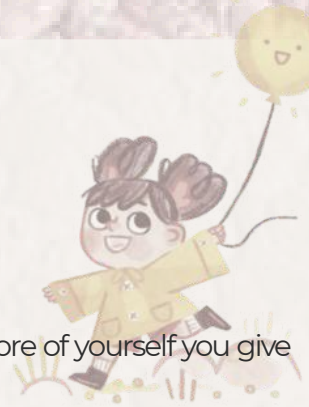
Melancholy studied her for a moment, eyes tracing the faintness at Joy's edges as she said: "Because you never leave whole."

Joy laughed, the sound rich of colors, easy and untroubled, "I always do."

Melancholy did not argue, she rarely did, and instead she reached out and placed her hand where Joy's sleeve thinned into light. Her fingers passed through.

Joy fell quiet.





"This is how it works," the grey eyed girl said. "The longer you remain, the more of yourself you give away, because while others feel lighter, you become less."

Joy looked down at herself then, at the way the glow she carried had dulled, as though it had been borrowed and never returned. She tried to summon the warmth she had just given so freely, but felt nothing back.

"Is it supposed to hurt?" Joy asked, not frightened, only curious.

Melancholy shook her head. "No, you were never meant to feel it."

Joy smiled at that, small and sincere. "Then I suppose it's fair."

Melancholy said nothing, she watched as Joy stepped away, already beginning to brighten again, though never quiet to what she had been before.

Some rules of the world were not enforced by force, by nature, and Melancholy had learned that the cruelest ones were also the gentlest.

It happens in a field too bright to look at for long.

Wildflowers bent gathered there, parents spread on the grass, hands brushing voices warm and unguarded. At the center stood a little girl, no older than six, her joy uncontained, spilling out of her in quick, breathless bursts as she ran through the flowers.

Joy knelt before her, and she gave herself freely, as she always did. The light poured from her in gentle waves, softening the world around them. The girl laughed, high and clear, and the sound caught, spreading outward into her parents' smiles, into the way the field seemed to glow brighter, fuller, alive.

Joy stayed. She stayed longer than she should have.

The happiness thickened, pooling in the air until it felt almost tangible, until even the flowers seemed to lean towards it. The little girl reached for Joy's hands, and Joy let her, smiling as the warmth passed cleanly through her palms and into the child's chest.

It was then that the sunlight began to slip through her.

At first, it was barely noticeable, a thinning at her sides, a lightness beneath her ribs. Then the sun shone straight through her torso, illuminating the flowers behind her heart as if there had never been anything solid there at all.

Joy did not pull away.

She watched the girl laugh, watched the happiness bloom where she had placed it, and felt nothing answer back inside herself. When she finally stepped away, her feet barely touched the ground.

She paused, as she always did.

Joy pressed a hand to her chest, standing alone at the edge of the field, and waited for warmth that never came.

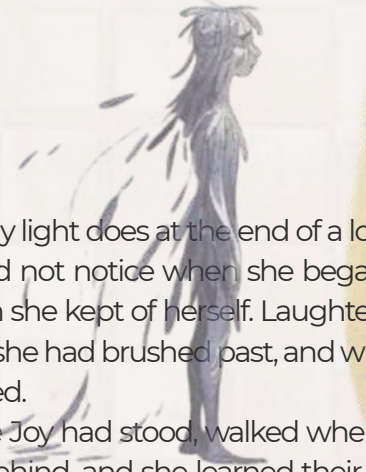
From the shade of a nearby tree, Melancholy watched her best friend vanishing in front of her.

Joy smiled and turned away. She did not notice how the world showed through her until Melancholy stepped in front of her, blocking the light, her hands closing around the little that remained of her friends. For a moment, Joy was held in shadow, and it was enough.

"You almost—" Melancholy began through trembling breaths.

Joy only laughed softly. "It's all right," she said. "This always happens."

Melancholy fell silent and walked beside her, knowing it wouldn't always be enough.



Joy faded the way light does at the end of a long day, not at all once, not dramatically, but so slowly that even she did not notice when she began to disappear. Each place she passes through kept more of her than she kept of herself. Laughter lingered in her wake, relief settled into chests, hope took root where she had brushed past, and with every gift, she thinned.

Melancholy stayed.

She stood where Joy had stood, walked where Joy had walked. Learned the weight of the empty spaces Joy left behind, and she learned their shapes, their warmth, the way they hummed faintly even after Joy was gone. When sunlight passed through where Joy once had ribs, Melancholy stepped into the gap, holding the light back with her shadow.

Once, only once, Melancholy reached for her before she could fade.

Joy had just finished giving herself away, light spilling from her in thin, fragile strands. She was already smiling, already turning, when Melancholy caught her wrist. It felt warm. Too warm. Like holding the last ember after a fire has burned out.

“Stay,” Melancholy whispers, the word breaking as soon as it leaves her mouth. “Just for a moment.” Joy looked back, surprised, as if she had not realized she could still be touched. “I can’t,” she said gently. “You know I never do.”

“I know,” Melancholy answers, tightening her grip anyways. “I just— I wanted to remember how you feel.”

For a heartbeat, Joy leaned into her best friend. The light between them flared, bright enough to hurt. Then it thinned. Then it slipped away. Melancholy’s hands closed around nothing at all.

When Joy finally disappeared, the world did not notice at first. People still smiled, laughter still came, fields still bloomed, and families still held one another tighter without knowing why. Happiness remained, but it arrived smaller now, quieter, harder to see. It slipped into moments instead of bodies, into memories instead of touch.

Joy was no longer a woman wandering between hearts. She paused before laughing. The warmth remembered after it had already gone. The feeling of having survived something and not knowing how.

Only Melancholy noticed the difference. She lingered in doorways Joy had once crossed, in fields Joy had once brightened, keeping the shape of her presence intact so it would not vanish completely. She carried Joy the only way she knew how, not by restoring her, but by remembering her fully.

Joy survived.

But she lost herself entirely.

And somewhere between sorrow and hope, between what was life and what was remembered, Melancholy remained, quietly holding happiness in place, so the world would never forget that it had once been alive.